

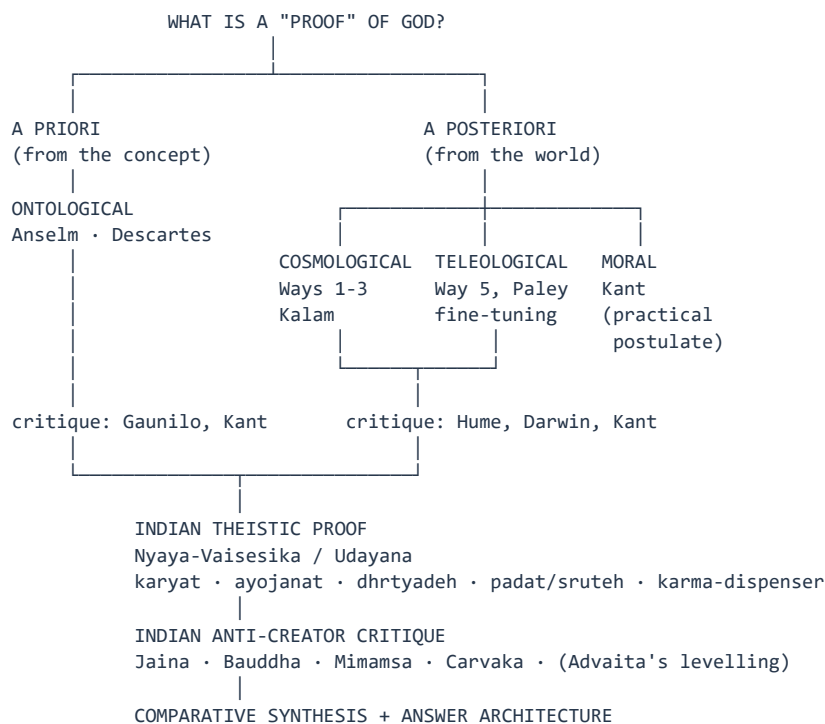
Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique — Complete Learning Session

UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Section B · Philosophy of Religion · Syllabus item 2

Date of session: 10 August 2026 · Progress: 0/8 · Estimated effort: 7–9 sittings

Evidence key used throughout: ✓ canonical doctrine directly grounded in the authored knowledge file or a local source text · △ analytical synthesis / inference for exam use · ? contested or textually variable · 📅 dated contemporary anchor only, never authority.

Roadmap



Session	Subtopic	Core focus
1	Architecture of theistic proof	Demonstration vs probable inference vs postulate; a priori/a posteriori; validity–soundness–adequacy
2	Ontological argument	Anselm's two forms, Descartes, Gaunilo, Kant, modal repair
3	Cosmological argument	Aquinas' Ways 1–3, essentially ordered series, Kalām, Hume and Kant
4	Teleological argument	Way 4 and Way 5, Paley, Hume's five-front critique, Darwin, fine-tuning
5	Moral argument	Kant's demolition and reinstatement; postulates; Newman; Euthyphro
6	Nyāya–Udayana theism	Kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt/sruteḥ, karma-dispenser, efficient-cause thesis
7	Indian anti-theistic critique	Jaina proofs and refutation; Buddhist anti-creator arguments; Mīmāṃsā apauruṣeya; Cārvāka

Session	Subtopic	Core focus
8	Comparative synthesis	India–West matrix, graded verdicts, 10/15/20-mark architecture

PYQ priority: ✓ Very high — 12 topic-owned question-parts across 2018–2025, spanning ontological (2018, 2020, 2024), Aquinas (2018, 2022), Nyāya (2018, 2023, 2025), design–Hume (2025), moral (2021), Jaina (2019), Buddhist (2018) and the a priori/a posteriori distinction (2022).

🔗 Master mnemonic — "O-C-T-M + N, then J-B-M": Ontological, Cosmological, Teleological, Moral, plus Nyāya; critiqued by Jaina, Bauddha, Mīmāṃsā.

Progress: 1 / 8 | Stage: Foundation | Subtopic: The Architecture of Theistic Proof

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Authored Markdown paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Proofs-for-God.md §0, §3, §11 read in full; local OCR-searchable John Hick, Philosophy of Religion, Chapter 2 ("Arguments for the Existence of God", pp. 15–29 of the print pagination) confirmed searchable and consulted.

🔍 CA Search: "cosmological, teleological and fine-tuning arguments for God's existence — scholarly debate 2025–2026"

📄 CA Found: 📄 A 2026 paper, "The Rational Defence of God's Existence: Exploring Cosmological...", and a 2025 review, "A Discourse On God's Existence: Cosmological And Teleological Proofs", both continue the cosmology/fine-tuning debate. Use only as a dated contemporary-debate anchor. It is not proof, and not canonical authority.



VISUAL — The three questions every proof must survive

PROOF FOR GOD

(1) VALIDITY	Does the conclusion follow from the premises as stated?
(2) SOUNDNESS	Are the premises actually true (causal principle, PSR, analogy)?
(3) ADEQUACY	Is the being reached actually GOD – infinite, one, personal, good?

A proof can be VALID, yet UNSOUND;
valid AND sound, yet still INADEQUATE to classical theism.

⚠️ This three-tier grid is the single most examiner-pleasing device in the whole topic. Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

1. What counts as a "proof" here?

✓ Three logically different things are all loosely called "proofs" in this syllabus item:

Type	Claim made	Standard example	If it fails, it fails as...
Demonstration	The conclusion follows necessarily; denial is contradictory	Anselm's ontological argument	invalid or question-begging
Probable / explanatory inference	God is the best or a required explanation of some feature of the world	Aquinas' Ways, Paley, Nyāya kāryāt	weak analogy, available rival explanation

Type	Claim made	Standard example	If it fails, it fails as...
Practical postulate	Belief is rationally required by the moral standpoint, not by theoretical proof	Kant's moral argument	a projection, or not binding on the sceptic

⚠ Never write "Kant proves God through morality." Kant explicitly denies theoretical proof; he postulates. This single sentence has sunk many otherwise good scripts.

2. A priori and a posteriori — the 2022 distinction

Axis	A priori	A posteriori
Starting point	✓ The concept of God alone	✓ Some fact of the world (motion, causation, contingency, order, moral experience)
Method	Conceptual analysis; denial produces contradiction	Inference from effect to cause; inference to best explanation
Standard instance	Ontological (Anselm, Descartes)	Cosmological, teleological, moral, Nyāya Īśvara-anumāna
Modality of conclusion	✓ Necessary being, if it works at all	⚠ At best a probable, and often finite, cause
Independence from science	Total — no empirical premise	⚠ Exposed to Darwin, Big-Bang cosmology, multiverse models
Characteristic defeat	✓ Kant: "existence is not a real predicate"	✓ Hume: analogy is weak; effect underdetermines cause
Religious payoff	Reaches necessity but not obviously a personal God	Reaches an agent-like cause but not obviously an infinite one

🔗 Mnemonic — "CONCEPT versus COSMOS": a priori argues from the concept, a posteriori from the cosmos.

⚠ The 2022 examiner asks which should be preferred. The strongest answer is a graded one: a posteriori arguments are epistemically more respectable because they begin from something granted by the opponent, but they pay for it by reaching only a finite, probable cause; the a priori argument alone promises necessity, but it purchases that necessity by an inference that Kant showed to be illegitimate. Preference therefore depends on the criterion — evidential contact favours a posteriori, modal strength favours a priori, and religious adequacy is achieved by neither alone.

3. The five families in one frame

Family	Premise drawn from	Terminus reached	Chief critic
Ontological	✓ Concept of a maximally great being	Necessarily existing being	Gaunilo; Kant
Cosmological	✓ Motion, efficient causation, contingency	Unmoved mover / first cause / necessary being	Hume; Kant
Teleological	✓ Order, adaptation, fine order	Intelligent designer	Hume; Darwin
Moral	✓ The moral law and the highest good	God as practical postulate	Naturalist axiology; Euthyphro
Nyāya inference	✓ The world as kārya (composite effect)	Omniscient intelligent efficient cause (Īśvara)	Mīmāṃsā; Buddhism; Jainism; Cārvāka

4. Why UPSC cares

✓ The syllabus phrase is "Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique (Indian and Western)". The examiner is therefore testing four capacities at once:

RECONSTRUCT → the argument as numbered premises, not as a slogan
 EXPOSE → the hidden presupposition that carries the weight
 OBJECT/REPLY → the strongest critic, and the proponent's best answer
 GRADE → how far it succeeds, and what kind of God it delivers

Contemporary anchor

 Source/date: A 2026 paper (The Rational Defence of God's Existence: Exploring Cosmological...) and a 2025 literature review (A Discourse On God's Existence: Cosmological And Teleological Proofs).  Theme: Cosmological and teleological reasoning has migrated into dialogue with Big-Bang cosmology, fine-tuning of physical constants, and multiverse hypotheses.  Inference for the exam: This shows the debate is live, and supplies one contemporary opening line. It does not license writing modern physics into a Philosophy Optional answer in place of Anselm, Aquinas, Hume, Kant and Udayana.

UPSC traps

1.  Do not treat "proof" univocally: demonstration, probable inference and practical postulate have different success conditions.
2.  Do not say the ontological argument is a posteriori because Anselm "observes" that people have the idea of God — the premise is conceptual.
3.  Do not equate "a priori" with "certain" and "a posteriori" with "uncertain"; a priori reasoning can be invalid, and a posteriori reasoning can be strong.
4.  Distinguish validity from soundness from adequacy of the God established. Most critiques attack the second and third, not the first.
5.  Do not present the Indian material as a decorative appendix; Nyāya is a fully-formed a posteriori natural theology and belongs inside the taxonomy.
6.  A proof's failure does not establish atheism; it establishes only that that route does not compel.

Revision notes

- Theistic proofs divide into a priori (conceptual) and a posteriori (world-based) routes.
- Ontological is the only classical a priori proof; cosmological, teleological, moral and Nyāya are a posteriori.
- Assess every proof on three tiers: validity, soundness, adequacy of the God reached.
- Demonstration claims necessity; explanatory inference claims probability; postulation claims practical rationality.
- Kant's moral argument is a postulate, never a theoretical demonstration.
- A posteriori proofs begin from conceded facts but reach only a finite, probable cause.
- The a priori proof promises necessity but is charged with the existence-predicate fallacy.
- 2022 asked exactly this distinction plus a reasoned preference — answer with a criterion-based, graded verdict.
- Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna is a cosmological–teleological hybrid, not a separate exotic species.
- No single proof reaches the full God of developed religion; cumulative-case strategies attempt to repair this.

MCQ 1

Which statement most accurately captures the difference between the a priori and a posteriori arguments for God's existence?

- A. The a priori argument derives God's existence from an analysis of the concept of God, whereas a posteriori arguments infer God from some general feature of the observed world.
- B. The a priori argument is empirical and probabilistic, whereas a posteriori arguments are conceptual and necessary.
- C. The a priori argument is Indian in origin, whereas a posteriori arguments are exclusively Western.
- D. The a priori argument concludes to a finite designer, whereas a posteriori arguments conclude to a necessary being.

✓ Correct answer: A. The ontological argument unpacks the content of the God-concept; Aquinas' Ways, Paley's design argument, Kant's moral argument and Nyāya's kāryāt inference all begin from a feature of the world. B inverts the definitions, C is historically false (Nyāya is a posteriori and Indian), and D reverses the modal outcomes.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

An examiner writes in the margin: "You have shown the argument is valid but you have not shown it is adequate." What has the candidate failed to do?

- A. Show that the premises are empirically verifiable.
- B. Show that the being established by the argument possesses the attributes of the God of developed religion — unity, infinity, personality and goodness.
- C. Show that the argument is expressed in syllogistic form.
- D. Show that the argument was historically endorsed by Aquinas.

✓ Correct answer: B. Adequacy concerns the gap between "a first cause" or "an intelligent designer" and the God actually worshipped. Hume's proportioning principle and Kant's charge that the cosmological argument smuggles in the ontological are both adequacy-level attacks.

✓ Subtopic 1 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now classify any proof and locate any objection on the correct tier. Proceeding to the ontological argument.

Progress: 2 / 8 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Ontological Argument — Anselm, Descartes and their Critics

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Proofs-for-God.md §1(a), §8.1, §10; John Hick, Philosophy of Religion, "The Ontological Argument" — Anselm's two forms from Proslogion 2 and 3, Gaunilo's In Behalf of the Fool, Descartes' Meditations V, and the modern discussions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and Plantinga — all read from the local OCR-searchable PDF.

🔍 CA Search: "ontological argument, modal ontological argument, contemporary discussion 2025–2026"

📄 CA Found: No specific, credibly dated ontological-argument news item within the last six months. The 2025–26 cosmological/fine-tuning revival noted in Subtopic 1 is the nearest live anchor, and is used only there. This subtopic is therefore taught from canonical doctrine, as it should be.



VISUAL — The ontological argument as a reductio

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ASSUME (for reductio): God exists in the understanding ALONE
|
|   Premise A: God =def "that than which nothing greater
|               can be conceived" (aliquid quo nihil maius cogitari possit)
|
|   Premise B: To exist in reality is greater than
|               to exist in the understanding alone
|
▼
THEN a greater than God can be conceived
     (namely, the same being existing in reality too)
▼
BUT that contradicts Premise A – "the greatest conceivable"
     cannot be exceeded by anything conceivable
▼
THE ASSUMPTION IS FALSE. God exists in reality.           [Proslogion 2]
▼
SECOND FORM: a being that CANNOT be thought not to exist
               is greater than one that can.
               God exists NECESSARILY (aseity, self-existence). [Proslogion 3]
  
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⚠ The second form is the philosophically serious one. It shifts the claim from existence to necessary existence, and it is the form Anselm uses to answer Gaunilo.

1. Anselm's definition — and why its wording matters

✓ Anselm compresses the monotheistic concept of God into the formula "a being than which nothing greater can be conceived." "Greater" here means more perfect, not spatially larger.

✓ Crucial textual point: Anselm deliberately does not say "the most perfect being that there is". That description would be trivially satisfied by whatever happens to be the best existing thing, with no guarantee that it is God. He says "so perfect that no more perfect can even be conceived". The argument is built on the second, stronger notion.

✓ Anselm addresses the Psalmist's "fool" who says in his heart, "There is no God." Even the fool, says Anselm, possesses the concept; and when the concept is unpacked, the fool is refuted out of his own understanding.

2. The two forms, side by side

	First form — Proslogion 2	Second form — Proslogion 3
Conclusion	God exists in reality as well as in the mind	God exists necessarily; God's non-existence is inconceivable
Key comparative	Existing in reality > existing in the mind alone	Being unable to be thought not to exist > being able to be so thought
Core notion	Existence	✓ Necessary being / aseity (self-existence)
Vulnerable to	Gaunilo's island parody; Kant's predicate objection	⚠ The charge that "necessary existence" is itself an incoherent or unestablished notion
Modern descendants	—	✓ Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga's modal versions

✓ Because God as infinitely perfect is not limited in or by time, the two possibilities of God's ever coming to be or ever ceasing to be are alike excluded; God's non-existence is thereby rendered impossible.

3. Descartes' reformulation

✓ Descartes (Meditations V) recasts the argument through his doctrine of clear and distinct ideas: existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as necessarily as having three angles summing to two right angles belongs to the essence of a triangle, or as a valley belongs to the idea of a mountain. A supremely perfect being that lacked existence would lack a perfection, which is a contradiction in terms.

⚠ Distinction to state in the answer: Anselm argues by reductio from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from essence containment ("existence is a perfection"). Both are a priori, but their machinery differs, and Kant's objection strikes Descartes' version most directly.

⚠ Descartes elsewhere offers a different, causal proof of God (from the idea of the infinite in a finite mind, Meditations III). Do not fuse the two; the causal one is not ontological.

4. Objection 1 — Gaunilo's lost island

✓ Gaunilo, a monk of Marmoutiers and Anselm's contemporary, replied in a tract titled In Behalf of the Fool. He argued that Anselm's reasoning would generate absurd conclusions elsewhere, and constructed a parallel argument for the most perfect island: given the idea of such an island, Anselm's principle would force us to conclude that it exists, since otherwise it would not be the most perfect conceivable island.

⚠ Precision point rarely made in scripts: Gaunilo actually spoke of the most perfect of islands rather than, as he should have, the most perfect conceivable island. Making that correction strengthens the parody, and stating the correction shows the examiner that you have read the debate rather than a summary of it.

✓ Anselm's reply rests on the second form. The element present in the concept of God and absent from the concept of any island is necessary existence. An island — "a piece of land surrounded by water" — is by definition part of the

contingent physical world, a dependent reality that can without contradiction be thought not to exist. Anselm's principle therefore does not apply to it. It applies only to a being defined as having eternal and independent existence.

⚠ Residual pressure: the reply protects the second form but leaves the first form exposed, and it transfers the entire burden to a further question — is the idea of a maximally great being coherent at all? If "most perfect conceivable island" is incoherent (because island-perfections have no intrinsic maximum), the parody fails; but the theist must then show that maximal greatness does have an intrinsic maximum.

5. Objection 2 — Kant: existence is not a real predicate

✓ Kant's objection is the decisive one in the tradition: "existence is not a real predicate." A real (determining) predicate adds something to the concept of a subject. Existence adds nothing to a concept; it posits the concept's object. Kant's illustration: a hundred real thalers contain not one coin more than a hundred possible thalers; the concept is identical, only my financial position differs.

✓ Chatterjee and Datta make the same point in the Indian textbook tradition, and put it in an idiom worth borrowing: the idea of one hundred rupees in my pocket involves the image or the idea of their existence, but not their real physical existence. To think of the existence of something is not to prove its existence.

⚠ Therefore: you cannot define anything into existence. From an analysis of a concept only conditional propositions follow — if such a being exists, it exists necessarily — and the antecedent is exactly what was to be proved.

6. Objection 3 — the modern logical objection

⚠ On the standard post-Fregean analysis, "exists" is not a first-order property of individuals but a second-order quantificational notion: to say tigers exist is to say the concept tiger is instantiated. If that is right, "existence" cannot appear in the list of perfections at all, and the argument cannot even be stated in its classical form.

7. The reply — modal ontological arguments

⚠ Twentieth-century defenders (Malcolm, Hartshorne, and in the most discussed form Plantinga) work exclusively with Anselm's second form and with necessary existence, which they claim is not vulnerable to Kant's objection because it is a modal status rather than a bare existence-predicate. The skeleton is:

1. It is POSSIBLE that a maximally great being exists.
2. A maximally great being is one that exists necessarily and is maximally excellent in every possible world.
3. If it is possible that such a being exists, then it exists in some possible world.
4. Whatever exists necessarily in some possible world exists in every possible world.
5. A maximally great being exists — in the actual world.

⚠ The burden simply migrates. The whole weight now rests on premise 1 — the possibility premise. A parallel "it is possible that no maximally great being exists" yields, by the same modal logic, the opposite conclusion. So the modal version does not prove God; it converts the dispute into a dispute about whether maximal greatness is genuinely possible, i.e. coherent. ✓ This is precisely the point the authored knowledge file records: "Possibility premise bears the burden."

8. Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? — the 2018 formulation

✓ 2018, Q6(c), 15 marks: "Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument."

⚠ Model verdict: the concept of God entails existence conceptually — i.e. it is analytic that God, if God exists, exists necessarily and not contingently — but conceptual entailment does not deliver instantiation. The argument proves at most a conditional: if the concept of a maximally great being is coherent and instantiable, then it is instantiated necessarily. What it cannot do is establish the antecedent by conceptual means alone. Hence: entailment within the concept, yes; entailment to reality, no.

9. Is there an Indian ontological argument?

⚠ There is no exact classical Indian analogue of the ontological argument. This is itself an examinable observation, and the reason is structural:

Feature of Indian epistemology	Consequence for an a priori proof
✓ Nyāya recognises pratyakṣa, anumāna, upamāna, śabda — all of which are contentful, world-involving pramāṇas	An argument with no empirical premise has no recognised evidential source
✓ Nyāya inference requires vyāpti (invariable concomitance) established by observed co-presence	Pure conceptual analysis cannot generate vyāpti
✓ Advaita reaches Brahman through śruti plus anubhava, not through concept-analysis	Brahman is not established by definition but disclosed
⚠ Mīmāṃsā treats the Veda as intrinsically valid and authorless	No conceptual route to a divine being is needed or offered

⚠ Safe comparative sentence: "Indian natural theology is overwhelmingly a posteriori and inferential; the ontological route has no classical Indian counterpart because Indian epistemology grounds existence-claims in pramāṇas that are world-involving."



Advanced refinement

⚠ Anselm's argument is better read as *fides quaerens intellectum* — faith seeking understanding — than as a neutral proof aimed at converting the atheist. On that reading, its function is to display the internal grammar of the God-concept for one who already believes: God is not one more entity that happens to exist, but that whose non-existence is unthinkable. This does not save it as a proof, but it explains its extraordinary durability, and it is a mature line to deploy in the concluding paragraph of a 20-marker.

India–West comparison

	Ontological (West)	Nyāya inference (India)
Type	✓ A priori, conceptual	✓ A posteriori, inferential
Starting point	Concept of maximal greatness	The world as composite effect (kārya)
Conclusion's modality	Necessary existence	⚠ Probable existence of an intelligent agent
Characteristic objection	Existence is not a real predicate	Weak world–artefact analogy; karma may suffice
Divine attributes reached	Maximal perfection by definition	Omniscience, eternity, agency — argued for stepwise

UPSC traps

- ⚠ Do not present only Proslogion 2 and omit the second form; Anselm's reply to Gaunilo requires the second form.
- ⚠ Gaunilo is not Kant. Gaunilo offers a parody (the form proves too much); Kant offers a diagnosis (the form uses "existence" illegitimately).
- ⚠ Do not attribute the island example to Kant, or the thaler example to Gaunilo.
- ⚠ Descartes' ontological proof (Meditations V) must not be confused with his causal proof from the idea of the infinite (Meditations III).
- ⚠ The modal version does not defeat Kant "cleanly"; it relocates the problem to the possibility premise.
- ⚠ Do not say the ontological argument is "obviously absurd". It is the argument that has attracted the most sustained modern logical attention of all the proofs.
- ⚠ Do not manufacture an "Indian ontological argument" out of Advaita. Brahman is not established by conceptual analysis.

🔗 Mnemonic — "A-D-G-K-M": Anselm defines, Descartes essentialises, Gaunilo parodies, Kant diagnoses, Modal logic repairs (and re-buries the burden).

Revision notes

- Anselm defines God as that than which nothing greater can be conceived — "greater" means more perfect.
- Proslogion 2 argues that existing in reality is greater than existing in the mind alone.
- Proslogion 3 upgrades the conclusion to necessary existence rooted in aseity.
- Descartes makes existence a perfection contained in the essence of a supremely perfect being.
- Gaunilo's In Behalf of the Fool offers the perfect-island parody.
- Anselm answers that only God is defined as having necessary, non-contingent existence.
- Kant: existence is not a real predicate; a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones.
- Chatterjee–Datta echo this with the hundred-rupees illustration.
- Frege-style analysis makes existence a second-order quantificational notion, not a perfection.
- Modal versions (Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga) shift the burden onto the possibility premise.
- 2018 asks about concept-to-existence entailment; the correct verdict is conditional entailment without instantiation.
- There is no classical Indian ontological argument, for pramāṇa-theoretic reasons.

MCQ 1

Which of the following correctly states Anselm's reply to Gaunilo's parody?

- A. Gaunilo's island exists, but it is less perfect than God.
- B. The concept of God, unlike the concept of an island, includes necessary existence, so the parallel fails because an island is by definition a contingent, dependent reality.
- C. Gaunilo misquoted the Proslogion, and the argument therefore does not apply.
- D. The argument was never intended to apply to material objects because material objects are unreal.

✓ Correct answer: B. Anselm falls back on the second form: only a being defined as eternal and self-existent can be subject to the inference. An island, being a piece of land surrounded by water, is by definition part of the contingent physical world.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

Kant's claim that "existence is not a real predicate" most directly undermines which step?

- A. Anselm's initial definition of God.
- B. Gaunilo's island parody.
- C. The step that treats existence as a perfection or great-making property whose addition makes a concept greater.
- D. The claim that God is eternal.

✓ Correct answer: C. Kant's target is the assumption that existence functions as a determining predicate that can be added to a concept to enhance it. This is precisely the comparative that both Anselm's first form and Descartes' essence-containment version require.

✓ Subtopic 2 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. Proceeding to the cosmological family.

Progress: 3 / 8 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Cosmological Family — Aquinas' Ways 1–3 and the Kalām

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Proofs-for-God.md §1(b), §8.2, §10; John Hick, Philosophy of Religion, "The First-Cause and Cosmological Arguments", read from the local PDF — including Hick's report that Aquinas himself elsewhere concedes

the difficulty of excluding an endless regress (Summa Theologica I q.46 a.2; Summa Contra Gentiles II.38) and that neo-Thomists reinterpret the excluded series as non-temporal.

🔍 CA Search: "cosmological argument, Kalam, Big Bang, principle of sufficient reason — recent scholarly debate 2025–2026"

📖 CA Found: 📖 The 2025 review A Discourse On God's Existence: Cosmological And Teleological Proofs surveys the cosmological argument through Leibniz's Principle of Sufficient Reason and the Kalām form, and engages infinite regress, Big Bang cosmology, quantum mechanics and multiverse hypotheses. Dated contemporary anchor only; not authority, not proof.



VISUAL — Two kinds of causal series (the whole argument turns on this)

ACCIDENTALLY ORDERED (per accidens) – Aquinas does NOT need to stop this
 great-grandfather → grandfather → father → son
 Each cause can perish and the effect continues.
 An infinite backward series here is not obviously incoherent.

ESSENTIALLY ORDERED (per se) – THIS is what Aquinas terminates
 HAND → moves → STICK → moves → STONE
 Remove the hand and the whole series stops NOW.
 Every intermediate member has only DERIVATIVE power.
 An infinite series of borrowers with no owner explains nothing.

"FIRST" = EXPLANATORY PRIORITY, not the earliest event in time.

⚠️ This diagram is the single highest-value item in the cosmological answer. The commonest UPSC error is to reduce all five Ways to "everything had a beginning, so God started it", which is neither Aquinas' argument nor a good argument.

1. Aquinas' Five Ways — the map before the detail

✓ Aquinas offers five ways of proving divine existence (Summa Theologiae I, q.2, a.3). Unlike the ontological argument, which focuses on the idea of God and unfolds its inner implications, Aquinas' proofs start from some general feature of the world around us and argue that there could not be a world with this particular characteristic unless there also existed the ultimate reality we call God.

Way	Starts from	Terminates in
1	✓ Change / motion	Prime Mover (unmoved mover)
2	✓ Efficient causation	First Cause
3	✓ Contingent beings (possibility and necessity)	Necessary Being
4	✓ Degrees of value and perfection	Absolute Value / maximum
5	✓ Evidence of purposiveness in nature	Divine Designer

⚠️ Ways 1–3 constitute the cosmological family; Way 4 is the henological / degrees argument; Way 5 is the teleological one, treated in Subtopic 4. Each concludes with Aquinas' cautious formula, "and this everyone understands to be God" — a phrase that itself concedes that further theological work is needed to identify the terminus with the God of religion.

2. Way 1 — from motion

✓ Reconstruction:

1. Some things in the world are in motion (in the broad sense: undergoing change, passing from potentiality to actuality).
2. Whatever is moved is moved by another; nothing can be in potentiality and actuality in the same respect at the same time.
3. That mover, if itself moved, requires a further mover.
4. An essentially ordered series of movers cannot proceed to infinity, for then there would be no first mover and hence no motion now.
5. There is a first, unmoved mover – "and this everyone understands to be God."

⚠ Presupposition: the act–potency analysis of change, and the claim that derivative causal power must be traced to non-derivative power here and now.

✓ Canonical example (state it in the answer): the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick. The stick has no power of its own; its causal efficacy is borrowed. This is what makes the series essentially ordered.

3. Way 2 — from efficient causation

✓ Reconstruction: In the observable world there is an order of efficient causes. Nothing is the efficient cause of itself, for it would then have to be prior to itself. In an ordered series of efficient causes, the first is the cause of the intermediate and the intermediate of the last; take away the cause and you take away the effect. An infinite regress of such causes would remove the first, and hence the intermediate and the last. Therefore a first efficient cause must be admitted.

⚠ ✓ Hick's assessment, worth reporting: the weakness of the argument as Aquinas states it lies in the difficulty — which Aquinas himself elsewhere acknowledges — of excluding as impossible an endless regress of events requiring no first state. ✓ Neo-Thomists reformulate it by insisting that the excluded series is not a regress of events back in time but an endless and therefore eternally inconclusive series of dependent causes existing simultaneously.

⚠ Do not miss the historical point: Aquinas holds, on philosophical grounds alone, that the universe could be eternal; that it began is known by faith, not demonstration. So Way 2 is not, and cannot be, an argument for a temporal beginning.

4. Way 3 — from contingency

✓ Reconstruction:

1. We find things that are possible-to-be and possible-not-to-be (they are generated and corrupted).
2. What is possible-not-to-be at some time is not.
3. If everything were contingent, then at some time nothing would have existed.
4. If nothing existed at some time, nothing would exist now, since what does not exist begins to exist only through something that already exists.
5. Not all beings are merely possible; there must be something NECESSARY.
6. Every necessary being either has its necessity from another or from itself; the series of necessity-from-another cannot regress infinitely.
7. There exists a being necessary of itself – "this all men speak of as God."

⚠ Two vulnerable steps. (i) Step 3 arguably commits a quantifier shift: from "for each thing there is a time at which it does not exist" it does not follow that "there is a time at which no thing exists". (ii) Step 6 needs the distinction — Aquinas himself makes it — between beings necessary *ab alio* (angels, on his scheme) and the being necessary *a se*.

⚠ Precision worth writing: Way 3 is not the same as Way 2. Way 2 concerns causal dependence; Way 3 concerns modal status — contingency versus necessity. A script that merges them loses the very distinction the 2022 question was testing.

5. Way 4 — from degrees of perfection

✓ Reconstruction: Among beings there are some more and some less good, true and noble. But "more" and "less" are predicated of things according as they resemble in different degrees something which is the maximum. Therefore there must be something which is truest, best and noblest, and consequently something which is the cause of being, goodness and every perfection in all things — and this we call God.

⚠ This is the least popular Way and the one most exposed to the objection that comparative judgements do not require an existing maximum (a "hottest possible thing" is not entailed by degrees of heat). Its defence requires the Platonic-Aristotelian machinery of participation and of a cause containing eminently what it confers.

⚠ It is nonetheless the Way most useful for showing the examiner that you understand Aquinas' metaphysics of participation rather than only his causal reasoning.

6. The Kalām cosmological argument

✓ The Kalām form, which originates in Islamic philosophical theology and has been revived in modern discussion, is structurally different from Aquinas:

1. Whatever BEGINS to exist has a cause of its beginning.
2. The universe began to exist.
3. The universe has a cause of its beginning.
(+ conceptual analysis: that cause is beginningless, uncaused, changeless, timeless, immaterial, enormously powerful – and personal, since only agency explains a temporal effect from a timeless cause.)

⚠ Contrast to state explicitly: the Kalām argues for a temporal beginning and therefore engages Big-Bang cosmology directly; Aquinas' Ways deliberately do not require one. Collapsing the two is the standard textbook error.

7. Leibniz and the Principle of Sufficient Reason

⚠ Leibniz's version asks not "what started it?" but "why is there something rather than nothing?" Every fact requires a sufficient reason; the totality of contingent facts is itself contingent; therefore its sufficient reason must lie in a necessary being. This is the version that engages the modern brute-fact debate.

8. Objections and replies

Objection	Aimed at	Reply	Residual pressure
✓ Hume: why not an infinite series, with each member explained by its predecessor?	Ways 1–3	⚠ The series concerned is essentially ordered; an infinite set of derivative causes still has no non-derivative actualising power	⚠ Requires proving the series is essentially ordered, not merely asserting it
✓ Hume: explaining each member explains the whole; the demand for a cause of the collection is illegitimate	Leibnizian version	⚠ A contingent totality is not made self-explanatory by enlarging the set	? Tracks a genuine dispute over the scope of the PSR
✓ Fallacy of composition: because each part has a cause, the whole need not	Cosmological family	⚠ The argument concerns dependence, not the transfer of a shared property	⚠ Must be stated as an essentially ordered series to hold
✓ Kant: the cosmological argument covertly relies on the ontological	Ways 2–3	⚠ Thomists deny the covert reliance: they identify the necessary being with God through further metaphysical argument, not by definition	⚠ Even so, the identification is a separate and disputable stage
✓ Hume: why must the cause be one, personal, infinite or good?	All	⚠ Cumulative-case strategies add attributes from several arguments together	✓ No single proof reaches classical theism
⚠ Brute fact: the universe may simply be there	Leibnizian version	⚠ Explanatory demand does not evaporate merely because it is inconvenient	? Genuinely unresolved

⚠ Kant's objection, spelled out because it is frequently mis-stated: the cosmological argument concludes to a necessary being; but to move from "a necessary being" to "the most real being (ens realissimum), i.e. God", one must argue that only the most perfect being can be necessary — and that step is the ontological argument. Kant's point is therefore an adequacy-tier attack: the cosmological argument's own resources take it only to "something necessary", and it borrows the rest.

9. India–West comparison

	Aquinas (Ways 1–3)	Nyāya kāryāt
Starting fact	✓ Motion, causation, contingency	✓ The world is a composite effect

	Aquinas (Ways 1–3)	Nyāya kāryāt
Reason the world needs a cause	Derivative actuality requires non-derivative act	Composite parts + intermediate magnitude ⇒ producedness
Nature of the cause	✓ Pure act; creator of being itself	✓ Intelligent efficient cause who orders pre-existing eternal atoms
Material cause	God creates ex nihilo; no independent matter	✓ Eternal atoms are the material cause; God is not
Continuing relation	Conservation of being	✓ Creation, maintenance, destruction — hence theism, not deism
Chief internal difficulty	Regress-exclusion; identification with God	Analogy from artefact to world; sufficiency of karma

⚠ The single sharpest comparative sentence available for 2018 Q8(a): "Both are a posteriori inferences from features of the world to an intelligent ultimate cause; but Aquinas' God confers existence itself, whereas Nyāya's Īśvara confers only order upon eternally existing atoms and souls."

Advanced refinement

⚠ Note the difference in what the conclusion has to do. Aquinas needs a being that is ipsum esse subsistens — subsistent existence itself — because his question is why anything at all is actual. Udayana needs only an omniscient agent capable of knowing atoms and combining them. Consequently Hume's "finite effect, finite cause" objection bites harder against Aquinas' identification with the infinite God and differently against Nyāya, whose God is explicitly limited by co-eternal atoms, souls and adr̥ṣṭa. C. D. Sharma presses exactly this point from the Advaita side, complaining that the Vaiśeṣika God "has been reduced to the status of a supervisor" whose "hands and feet are chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the Adr̥ṣṭa."

UPSC traps

- ⚠ Do not merge the five Ways into one temporal "first cause" argument. They start from different features and terminate in differently described conclusions.
- ⚠ "First" means explanatory priority, not chronological firstness.
- ⚠ Aquinas does not argue that the universe began in time; he holds that its beginning is known by faith.
- ⚠ The Kalām does argue for a temporal beginning; it is not Aquinas' argument.
- ⚠ Do not attribute Paley's watch to Aquinas (see Subtopic 4).
- ⚠ Kant's objection is that the cosmological argument borrows the ontological argument, not that it is invalid on its own terms.
- ⚠ Way 3 is modal (contingency/necessity); Way 2 is causal. Keep them apart.
- ⚠ Do not say Hume "refuted" the cosmological argument; he attacked the necessity of the regress-stop and the identification of the cause with God.

🔗 Mnemonic — "MCC-DP": Motion, Causation, Contingency (the cosmological three); then Degrees and Purpose (Ways 4 and 5).

Revision notes

- Aquinas' Ways begin from general features of the world, unlike the a priori ontological argument.
- Way 1: motion → prime mover; Way 2: efficient causation → first cause; Way 3: contingency → necessary being.
- Way 4: degrees of perfection → maximum; Way 5: purposiveness → designer.
- The regress excluded is essentially ordered (hand–stick–stone), not accidentally ordered.
- "First" is explanatory, not temporal; Aquinas permits an eternal universe philosophically.
- Neo-Thomists reinterpret the excluded series as simultaneous dependence, not backward time.
- Kalām: whatever begins to exist has a cause; the universe began; therefore it has a cause.

- Leibniz's PSR version asks why there is something rather than nothing.
- Hume: infinite regress may be acceptable; explaining parts may explain the whole; the cause need not be God.
- Kant: the move from "necessary being" to "God" imports the ontological argument.
- Fallacy-of-composition charge is met by framing dependence rather than property-transfer.
- Aquinas' God causes being; Nyāya's Īśvara causes only order among eternal atoms.

MCQ 1

Aquinas' rejection of an infinite regress in the Second Way is best defended by pointing out that:

- A. Modern cosmology has proved that the universe had a beginning in time.
- B. An infinite set is a mathematically incoherent notion.
- C. The series he excludes is essentially ordered, so that every intermediate member has only derivative causal power and an infinite series of such members would supply no actualising power at all.
- D. Aquinas held that the universe was created in time and therefore no regress is possible.

✓ Correct answer: C. The hand–stick–stone illustration establishes that the members are simultaneous and derivative. A is anachronistic and irrelevant to Aquinas; B is false; D contradicts Aquinas, who held that the temporal beginning of the world is an article of faith, not a philosophical demonstration.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

Kant's criticism that the cosmological argument "secretly relies on the ontological argument" means that:

- A. The cosmological argument uses conceptual analysis in its first premise.
- B. The cosmological argument's premises are a priori.
- C. Aquinas plagiarised Anselm.
- D. The step from "there exists a necessary being" to "that being is God, the most real being" cannot be taken by cosmological reasoning alone and requires the ontological identification of maximal perfection with necessary existence.

✓ Correct answer: D. This is an adequacy-tier objection: the cosmological argument delivers "something necessary", and the theologically decisive identification is imported from elsewhere.

✓ Subtopic 3 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. Proceeding to design.

Progress: 4 / 8 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Teleological Argument — Way 5, Paley, Hume, Darwin, Fine-Tuning

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Proofs-for-God.md §1(c), §8.3; John Hick, Philosophy of Religion, "The Design (or Teleological) Argument", read from the local PDF — Paley's Natural Theology (1802), his three supplementary points, and Hick's numbered presentation of three of Hume's main criticisms from the Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion (1779), including the Epicurean hypothesis and the scales illustration.

🔍 CA Search: "design argument, fine-tuning of physical constants, multiverse, irreducible complexity — debate 2025–2026"

📄 CA Found: 📄 The 2025 review traces teleology from Paley's watchmaker to modern irreducible-complexity claims and notes that fine-tuning debate continues alongside evolutionary biology and genetics; the 2026 paper likewise argues from cosmic fine-tuning. Dated contemporary anchor only.



VISUAL — Three teleologies that must not be confused

- | |
|---|
| <p>(A) AQUINAS, FIFTH WAY — regularity of NON-COGNITIVE nature
Natural bodies without knowledge act for an end,
and do so ALWAYS or NEARLY ALWAYS in the same way.
Whatever lacks knowledge cannot move toward an end unless
directed by something with knowledge → as the ARROW by the
ARCHER. an intelligent being directs natural things.
NOT an analogy with human artefacts.</p> |
| <p>(B) PALEY (1802) — ANALOGY from ARTEFACT to ORGANISM
Watch on the heath : watchmaker :: eye, wing, fin : Designer
Biological means-end ADJUSTMENT is the evidence.
→ Directly vulnerable to Darwin.</p> |
| <p>(C) FINE-TUNING (modern) — PROBABILISTIC, not analogical
Cosmological constants lie in an extremely narrow life-permitting
range → design as inference to the best explanation.
Rivals: multiverse, anthropic selection, brute necessity.
→ NOT touched by Darwin, because it is pre-biological.</p> |

⚠ Reproducing this three-way distinction is what separates a 60% answer from a 75% answer in 2025 Q6(a). Most candidates write Paley, get demolished by Darwin, and stop.

1. Aquinas' Fifth Way — stated properly

✓ The design argument occurs in philosophical literature from Plato's *Timaeus* onward, and appears again as the last of Aquinas' five Ways.

✓ The Fifth Way is not an analogy with human manufacture. Its premise is that things which lack cognition nevertheless act for an end, and do so with regularity — which cannot be chance. Hence they are directed by an intelligent being, as the arrow is directed by the archer.

⚠ Why the difference matters: Darwinian natural selection is a direct competitor to Paley's premise (biological adaptation) but a much less direct competitor to Aquinas' premise (the regular law-like directedness of nature as such), which arguably persists after evolution is granted.

2. Paley's watch

✓ Paley's analogy of the watch conveys the essence of the argument. Walking in a desert place I see a stone, and may properly attribute its presence to the operation of natural forces — wind, rain, heat, frost, volcanic action. But if I find a watch, I cannot reasonably account for it in the same way. A watch consists of a complex arrangement of wheels, cogs, axles, springs and balances, all operating accurately together to give a regular measurement of time. I am obliged to postulate an intelligent mind responsible for the phenomenon.

✓ Paley's three supplementary points — quote them; they anticipate obvious replies:

- ✓ The inference is not weakened if I have never seen a watch made (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence.
- ✓ The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism does not always work perfectly — as may appear to be the case with the mechanism of the world.
- ✓ The inference is not undermined if there are parts whose function we cannot discover — as there are in nature.

✓ Paley then argues that the natural world is as complex a mechanism, and as manifestly designed, as any watch: the rotation of the planets, the procession of the seasons, the mutual adaptation of the parts of a living organism. The eye, in particular, is a superb optical instrument with self-adjusting lenses, colour sensitivity and long continuous operation; the bird's wing is suited to the air and the fish's fin to the water.

⚠ Paley's is a long cumulative argument drawing on virtually all the sciences of his day — not a single inference. Saying so is worth a mark.

3. Hume's critique — the 2025 question's centre of gravity

✓ The classic critique of the design argument occurs in David Hume's *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, published in 1779, twenty-three years before Paley's book — and Paley took no apparent account of it. That chronological point is a genuine fact worth stating, because it forestalls the naive assumption that Hume was replying to Paley.

Hume's attack proceeds on five fronts:

#	Front	Hume's argument	Tier attacked
1	✓ Any universe must look designed	There could not be a universe at all in which the parts were not adapted to one another to a considerable degree — there could not be birds that grew wings but, like fish, could not live in air. So apparent adaptation is not evidence of design; it is a precondition of any persisting order. He proposes the Epicurean hypothesis: a finite number of particles in random motion will, in unlimited time, pass through every possible combination; one such combination is a stable order — perhaps ours.	Soundness
2	✓ The analogy is weak	The universe is not particularly like a machine. One could as plausibly liken it to a great inert animal such as a crustacean, or to a vegetable — in which case the argument fails, since whether crustaceans and vegetables are designed is precisely the question at issue. Only if the world is strikingly analogous to a human artefact is there a basis for inferring a Designer.	Soundness
3	✓ Proportioning cause to effect	From a given effect we can infer only a cause sufficient to produce it; therefore from a finite world we can never infer an infinite creator. Hume's illustration: if I see one side of a pair of scales and observe that ten ounces is outweighed by the unseen side, I may infer that the unseen weight exceeds ten ounces — but never that it is infinite.	Adequacy
4	✓ Plurality and imperfection of designers	Great works are often built by many hands; the world may be the product of many deities, or an inferior deity, or a senile or infant one, or a bungled first attempt abandoned by its maker.	Adequacy
5	✓ Evil and disorder	The mixed character of the world — waste, suffering, disease, catastrophe — counts against inferring a designer who is both good and powerful.	Adequacy

⚠ ✓ The trap: Hume does not claim to prove that no designer exists. His target is the strength of the inference and the attributes of the being inferred. In the *Dialogues* Philo himself concedes a remote, undefined analogy between the

cause of order in the universe and human intelligence. Writing "Hume disproved design" is a factual error.

4. Darwin

✓ The Darwinian theory of natural selection gives a more concrete account of the apparently designed character of animal bodies. Small random variations occur in every generation; species are relatively well adapted because the less well-adapted have perished in the continual competition to survive and have not perpetuated their kind. The "struggle for survival", as a constant pressure toward better adaptation, lies behind the evolution of life into increasingly complex forms.

✓ Hick's ozone illustration reverses the design intuition beautifully: animal life is not sheltered by the ozone layer because God created the animals and then installed a filter for them; rather the ozone layer was there first, and only those forms of life capable of existing under the precise level of ultraviolet radiation that penetrates it have developed on earth.

⚠ Exact scope of Darwin's defeat: natural selection removes biological adaptation as evidence of design — that is, it removes Paley's premise. It does not touch (i) Aquinas' law-like directedness of non-cognitive nature, (ii) the fine-tuning of the physical constants that make chemistry and biology possible at all, or (iii) the question why there are law-governed regularities in the first place.

5. Fine-tuning and the probabilistic turn

⚠ Modern design reasoning is typically Bayesian or explanatory rather than analogical: the life-permitting values of certain cosmological parameters are said to be enormously improbable on chance, and less surprising on theism, so they raise the probability of theism.

Line of defence	Rival explanation	Assessment
⚠ Fine-tuning of constants	Multiverse plus observation-selection effect	? Neither decisively wins; the dispute is about the legitimacy of the probability assignments
⚠ Intelligibility and law-governedness of nature	Brute necessity; the laws could not have been otherwise	⚠ Shifts the question rather than closing it
⚠ Cumulative case (Swinburne-style)	Underdetermination — many hypotheses fit	⚠ Yields a probability claim, never a demonstration

📖 As noted, the 2025 review and 2026 paper both foreground exactly this migration — Paley → irreducible complexity → cosmic fine-tuning. ⚠ Use it as one contemporary sentence and no more. UPSC rewards Hume and Paley, not physics.

6. The Indian analogue — potter and pot

✓ Nyāya's inference is the closest Indian analogue: the world is treated as a vastly more complex kārya (effect) than a pot, and a pot's ordered parts warrant inference to a potter. ✓ Chatterjee and Datta observe that the Naiyāyika's causal argument strikingly resembles the reasoning of Western thinkers such as Paul Janet, Hermann Lotze and James Martineau, for whom the world of finite objects requires an intelligent cause giving order and co-ordination to its concurrent physical causes; Janet lays it down that all co-ordination between divergent phenomena implies a final cause or an intelligent agent. ✓ The Naiyāyika view of efficient cause as intelligent agent, they add, "strikingly anticipates Martineau's idea of cause as will directed to the realization of ends."

✓ But the decisive difference: Western theists generally believe God is not only the cause of the unity/order of things but also the creative energy that gives existence to the things of Nature. For the Naiyāyikas, God is only the cause of the order of Nature, and not of the existence of its ultimate constituents.

⚠ Hume's second objection — that the world is unlike an artefact — therefore lands on Nyāya with full force, since Nyāya's inference is explicitly artefact-modelled (ghaṭavat, "like a pot").

7. Solved PYQ — 2025, Q6(a), 20 marks

✓ Exact question: "Present an account of Design argument to prove the existence of God along with its criticism by David Hume."

Answer spine (write this shape, not a list):

1. CLASSIFY : teleological = a posteriori; distinguish Aquinas' Way 5 (regularity of non-cognitive nature, archer-arrow) from Paley's artefact ANALOGY.
2. RECONSTRUCT: Paley's watch on the heath + his three supplementary points (never seen one made; imperfect working; unknown parts) + the eye, wing, fin, seasons; note it is a CUMULATIVE argument.
3. CRITICISE : Hume, Dialogues (1779, PRIOR to Paley) on five fronts –
 - (a) any universe must look adapted; Epicurean hypothesis
 - (b) the world is as like a vegetable/animal as a machine
 - (c) proportion cause to effect: finite world at most finite cause (the scales illustration)
 - (d) many/imperfect/infant/absentee designers are equally supported
 - (e) evil and disorder count against a good designer
4. EXTEND : Darwin removes Paley's biological premise (ozone illustration); but fine-tuning relocates the argument to pre-biological constants.
5. GRADE : Hume defeats DEMONSTRATION and defeats the inference to the infinite, single, perfectly good God; he does not disprove design. Design survives only as inference to the best explanation.
6. CONCLUDE : teleology retains cumulative and religious force while forfeiting demonstrative status; it points beyond the world without compelling.

Advanced refinement

△ There is a deep asymmetry between objections (1)–(2) and (3)–(5). The first two say the evidence does not support design at all; the last three concede an inference but say it does not reach the God of religion. A candidate who separates these two waves demonstrates control of the argument's logical structure — and can then make the mature observation that the modern fine-tuning revival answers the first wave (by relocating the evidence to the constants) while remaining fully exposed to the second (a fine-tuner need not be one, infinite or good).

India–West comparison

	Paley / Way 5	Nyāya āyojanāt
Evidence	✓ Means–end adjustment in organisms; regular directedness in nature	✓ Purposive combination of inert atoms into an ordered world
Model	Watch → watchmaker; arrow → archer	✓ Pot → potter
Cause's role	Creates and orders	✓ Orders only; atoms are eternal
Cause's knowledge	Intelligence adequate to the design	✓ Omniscience, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities as simple and infinitesimal as atoms
Main critic	Hume, Darwin	Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Jainism, Cārvāka

UPSC traps

1. △ Paley's watch is not Aquinas'. Aquinas' Fifth Way is about the regular goal-directedness of non-cognitive nature.
2. △ Hume's Dialogues (1779) precede Paley's Natural Theology (1802).
3. △ Hume does not disprove a designer; he attacks inference-strength and divine attributes.
4. △ Darwin defeats Paley's biological premise, not every form of teleology.
5. △ Fine-tuning is probabilistic and pre-biological; it is not "Paley with physics".
6. △ "Irreducible complexity" is a modern, contested move — mention, never endorse.
7. △ Do not conflate the design argument with the problem of evil; evil enters here only as one of Hume's five fronts.
8. △ Nyāya's design-type inference reaches an orderer, not a creator of matter.

 Mnemonic — Hume's five fronts, "A-A-P-P-E": Any universe looks adapted · Analogy is weak · Proportion cause to effect · Plurality/imperfection of designers · Evil.

Revision notes

- Teleology runs from Plato's Timaeus through Aquinas' Fifth Way to Paley and modern fine-tuning.
- Aquinas' Fifth Way: unknowing natural bodies act regularly for ends, as the arrow is directed by the archer.
- Paley: the watch on the heath obliges us to postulate an intelligent maker.
- Paley's three riders: never seen one made; imperfect working; unknown parts.
- Paley's evidence is cumulative — eye, wing, fin, planetary motion, seasons.
- Hume front 1: any persisting universe must exhibit adaptation; Epicurean hypothesis.
- Hume front 2: the world is as like a vegetable or animal as a machine.
- Hume front 3: proportion cause to effect — a finite world yields at most a finite cause (scales illustration).
- Hume front 4: many, imperfect, infant or absentee designers fit the evidence equally.
- Hume front 5: evil and disorder tell against a good and powerful designer.
- Darwin supplies a naturalistic mechanism for adaptation; the ozone case reverses the design intuition.
- Fine-tuning relocates design to pre-biological constants; multiverse and anthropic selection are the rivals.
- Nyāya's āyojanāt is the Indian analogue, modelled on potter and pot, reaching an orderer of eternal atoms.
- Verdict: teleology survives as inference to the best explanation, not as demonstration.

MCQ 1

Which statement correctly distinguishes Aquinas' Fifth Way from Paley's design argument?

- A. Aquinas argues from the analogy between organisms and human artefacts, while Paley argues from the regularity of inanimate nature.
- B. Aquinas argues from the regular goal-directed activity of things that lack cognition, whereas Paley argues by analogy from the means–end adjustment of artefacts to that of organisms.
- C. Aquinas' argument is a priori, while Paley's is a posteriori.
- D. Aquinas' argument concludes to a finite designer, whereas Paley's concludes to a necessary being.

✓ Correct answer: B. Aquinas uses the archer–arrow model of direction; Paley uses the watch–watchmaker model of analogy. A inverts them; both are a posteriori, so C is false; and neither conclusion is as described in D.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

Which of Hume's criticisms is an adequacy-tier objection rather than an attack on the evidential support for design?

- A. Any universe capable of persisting must display mutual adaptation of parts.
- B. The universe resembles a vegetable or a crustacean at least as much as it resembles a machine.
- C. From a finite effect one may infer only a cause sufficient to produce it, so a finite world cannot establish an infinite creator.
- D. The Epicurean hypothesis shows that random combinations in unlimited time can yield a stable order.

✓ Correct answer: C. A, B and D all attack whether the evidence supports a designer at all. C concedes an inference and denies that it reaches the God of theism — an adequacy objection, the same tier as Kant's charge against the cosmological argument.

✓ Subtopic 4 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. Proceeding to the moral argument.

Progress: 5 / 8 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Moral Argument — Kant's Demolition and Reinstatement

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

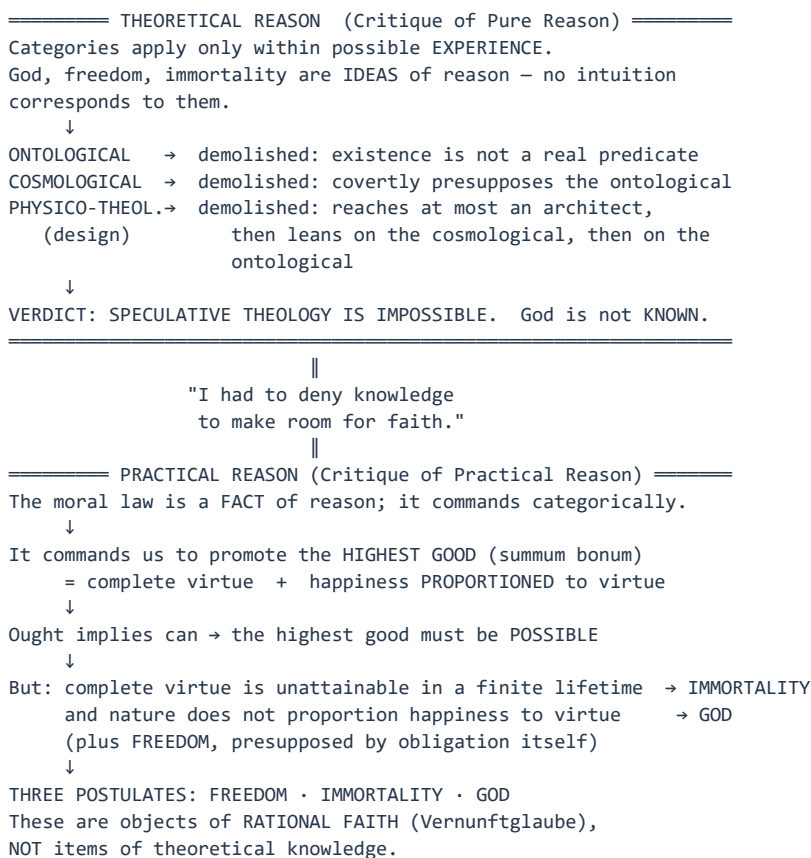
📖 Book context: Proofs-for-God.md §1(d), §8.5; paper-1/western/Kant.md; John Hick, Philosophy of Religion, "The Moral Argument", read from the local PDF — including Hick's division of the argument into a first form (inference from objective moral law to a divine Law Giver, illustrated by Newman's Grammar of Assent) and a second form (Kant's postulates, Critique of Practical Reason, Book II, Ch. 2), and Hick's verdict that the first form begs the question and the second cannot be presented as a proof.

🔍 CA Search: "moral argument for God's existence, divine command theory, contemporary debate 2025–2026"

📖 CA Found: No specific, credibly dated moral-argument item in the last six months. The 2026 paper noted earlier does list a moral argument within a cumulative case, but no independent dated development is available. Taught from canonical doctrine.



VISUAL — Kant's two-storey structure



⚠ The whole examinable point is in the architecture, not the content. Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs and the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

1. The first form of the moral argument — and why it fails

✓ Hick distinguishes a first form of the argument that is presented as a logical inference: from objective moral laws to a divine Law Giver; or from the objectivity of moral values to a transcendent Ground of Values; or from the fact of conscience to a God whose "voice" conscience is.

✓ Newman's version (A Grammar of Assent, 1870): "If, as is the case, we feel responsibility, are ashamed, are frightened, at transgressing the voice of conscience, this implies that there is One to whom we are responsible, before whom we are ashamed, whose claims upon us we fear... If the cause of these emotions does not belong to this visible world, the Object to which the conscientious person's perception is directed must be Supernatural and Divine."

✓ Hick's objection: the basic assumption of all such arguments is that moral values are not capable of naturalistic explanation — in terms of human needs, desires, ideals, self-interest, or the structure of human nature or society. To make that assumption is to beg the question. An essential premise of the inference from axiology to God is precisely what is in dispute; from the sceptic's standpoint nothing has been established.

2. Kant's second form — the postulates

✓ The second kind of moral argument "is not open to the same objection, for it is not strictly a proof at all." It claims that anyone seriously committed to respecting moral values as exercising a sovereign claim upon their life must thereby implicitly believe in a transhuman source and basis for those values.

✓ Kant's own structure (Critique of Practical Reason, Book II, Ch. 2):

1. The moral law categorically obligates the will; obligation presupposes FREEDOM.
2. The complete object of a morally determined will is the HIGHEST GOOD: virtue (worthiness to be happy) together with happiness proportioned to it.
3. Reason commands us to promote the highest good; "ought implies can", so the highest good must be really possible.
4. Perfect conformity of the will to the moral law (holiness) cannot be achieved by a finite being at any moment of its existence
→ an endless progress is required → POSTULATE OF IMMORTALITY.
5. Nature and morality are causally independent; a finite agent cannot ensure that happiness follows virtue → a cause of the whole of nature, distinct from nature, possessing intelligence and will, must be postulated
→ POSTULATE OF GOD.
6. These are postulates of PRACTICAL reason: theoretically undemonstrable propositions inseparably attached to an unconditionally valid practical law.

⚠ Three postulates, not one. Freedom, immortality and God. Many scripts mention only God and lose the systematic point.

3. What a postulate is — and is not

A postulate of practical reason is	A postulate is not
⚠ A proposition whose acceptance is rationally required if the moral law is to be coherently obeyed	✓ A speculative demonstration
⚠ An object of Vernunftglaube — rational faith	✓ An empirical hypothesis confirmable by evidence
⚠ Practically necessary, theoretically undecidable	✓ A theoretical extension of knowledge
⚠ Subjectively sufficient, objectively insufficient assent	✓ A dogma imposed on the sceptic

✓ Hick's verdict, which is also the safest exam verdict: to recognise moral claims as taking precedence over all other interests is implicitly to believe in a reality other than the natural world that is superior to oneself and entitled to one's obedience. This is "at least a move in the direction of belief in God". But it cannot be presented as a proof, because the sovereign authority of moral obligation can itself be questioned; and even if moral values point toward a transcendent ground, they cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, omnipotent, self-existent, personal creator of biblical faith.

4. Objections and replies

Objection	Force	Reply	Residual
✓ It assumes moral values resist naturalistic explanation (Hick, against the first form)	Fatal to Newman-type inference	⚠ Kant's version does not infer from values to a Lawgiver; it postulates conditions of the highest good	⚠ But the sceptic may deny the highest good is obligatory
⚠ Wish-fulfilment / projection: the postulate merely dresses up a desire for cosmic fairness	Serious	⚠ Kant answers that the postulate arises from the structure of moral reason, not from reward-seeking; acting for reward would be heteronomy and would destroy moral worth	⚠ The line between "rational hope" and "consoling wish" is thin
⚠ Autonomy tension: if morality is autonomous, why does it need God at all?	Serious and internal	⚠ Kant does not ground obligation in God; God enters only for the realisability of the highest good	⚠ Some Kantians (and Kant in places) suggest the highest good could be reconceived so as not to need the postulate

Objection	Force	Reply	Residual
✓ Euthyphro dilemma: is the good good because God wills it, or does God will it because it is good?	Fatal to divine-command versions	⚠ Kant is untouched: for him the moral law is not divine command; God is the guarantor of proportion, not the source of obligation	✓ Useful to show which versions the dilemma actually hits
⚠ Adequacy: postulation reaches a moral governor, not the God of religion	Standard	⚠ Kant grants it: he claims practical faith, not theology	✓ Reinforces the "no single proof reaches classical theism" thesis

5. The Indian counterpart — Nyāya's karmaphaladātā

✓ This is a genuine and underused comparison. Chatterjee and Datta, expounding the Nyāya argument from *adṛṣṭa*, write that God "combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice" — and note explicitly: "Or, as Kant would say, it is God who combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice."

	Kant	Nyāya
Problem addressed	⚠ Nature does not proportion happiness to virtue	✓ Unconscious <i>adṛṣṭa</i> cannot allot determinate fruits
Role assigned to God	Postulated author of a nature in which the highest good is possible	✓ Karmaphaladātā — actual dispenser of the fruits of action, the moral governor
Epistemic status	⚠ Practical postulate; theoretically undemonstrable	✓ Conclusion of an <i>anumāna</i> , claimed as knowledge
Where the proportioning happens	Beyond this life, over an endless progress	✓ Across this and previous lives, through <i>adṛṣṭa</i>
Chief rival	Naturalistic ethics	✓ <i>Mīmāṃsā</i> : karma is self-operating; no dispenser is needed

⚠ Sharp exam sentence: "Kant postulates a God who could proportion happiness to virtue; Nyāya infers a God who actually does. The Indian argument is therefore epistemically bolder and correspondingly more exposed — it must show that an unconscious principle could not do the job."

6. Solved PYQ — 2021, Q7(b), 15 marks

✓ Exact question: "Give a critical account of moral argument to prove the existence of God."

FRAME : Kant's two storeys – speculative proofs destroyed in CPR;
God re-entered in CPR as practical postulate.

STATE : Two forms – (i) inference from objective moral law/conscience to a Lawgiver (Newman); (ii) Kant's postulation from the highest good.

BUILD : moral law → highest good → ought implies can → virtue unattainable in finite time (immortality) + nature does not proportion happiness to virtue (God). Three postulates: freedom, immortality, God.

CRITIQUE: (a) first form begs the question against naturalistic axiology;
(b) projection/wish-fulfilment charge; (c) autonomy tension;
(d) Euthyphro hits divine-command, not Kant;
(e) adequacy – reaches a moral governor, not the biblical creator.

COMPARE : Nyāya's karmaphaladātā – same problem, stronger epistemic claim.

GRADE : as a PROOF it fails and was never offered as one; as an account of the practical presuppositions of the moral life it retains force.

CONCLUDE: the moral argument does not prove God; it shows what a serious moral agent must hope, which is a different and more defensible claim.



Advanced refinement

⚠ Kant's own later thought puts pressure on the postulate. If the highest good is redescribed as an ethical commonwealth achievable through human moral community, the theological postulate becomes less indispensable. Conversely, if the highest good genuinely requires a proportioning of nature to desert, no naturalistic substitute is available. So the argument's fate turns entirely on how the highest good is specified — a point worth one sentence in a 15-marker and a full paragraph in a 20-marker.

UPSC traps

1. ⚠ Kant does not prove God through morality. He postulates God for practical reason. This is the topic's most penalised error.
2. ⚠ Three postulates — freedom, immortality, God — not one.
3. ⚠ Newman's conscience argument is not Kant's; keep the two forms separate.
4. ⚠ God is not the source of moral obligation for Kant; the moral law is autonomous.
5. ⚠ Euthyphro refutes divine-command theories, not Kant's postulate.
6. ⚠ "Ought implies can" applies to promoting the highest good, not to achieving it single-handedly.
7. ⚠ Do not present the postulate as a reward-motive; that would be heteronomy and would destroy moral worth on Kant's own terms.
8. ⚠ Do not omit the Indian comparison; karmaphaladātā is the natural Indian counterpart.

🔗 Mnemonic — "F-I-G": Freedom, Immortality, God — Kant's three postulates.

Revision notes

- Kant destroys the ontological, cosmological and physico-theological proofs in the Critique of Pure Reason.
- He shows the cosmological and design arguments ultimately lean on the ontological.
- In the Critique of Practical Reason he postulates God, immortality and freedom.
- The moral law is a fact of reason and commands categorically.
- Its complete object is the highest good: virtue plus proportionate happiness.
- Ought implies can, so the highest good must be possible.
- Holiness is unattainable in finite time, hence immortality is postulated.
- Nature does not proportion happiness to virtue, hence God is postulated.
- A postulate is practically necessary and theoretically undemonstrable — rational faith.
- Newman's conscience argument is the first form and begs the question against naturalism.
- Hick: the moral argument moves toward belief in God but cannot reach the infinite personal creator.
- Euthyphro strikes divine-command theories, not Kant's postulate.
- Nyāya's karmaphaladātā is the Indian analogue; Chatterjee–Datta explicitly invoke Kant.
- Verdict: not a proof, but a defensible account of the practical presuppositions of moral seriousness.

MCQ 1

Which statement correctly describes Kant's position on the moral argument?

- A. Kant offers the moral argument as a theoretical demonstration replacing the failed cosmological proof.
- B. Kant argues that God is the source of moral obligation and that the moral law is a divine command.
- C. Kant treats God as a postulate of practical reason, required for the real possibility of the highest good, and denies that this constitutes theoretical knowledge of God.
- D. Kant rejects immortality while accepting God as a postulate.

✓ Correct answer: C. A misstates the epistemic status; B converts Kant into a divine-command theorist and contradicts his doctrine of autonomy; D omits one of the three postulates.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

The Euthyphro dilemma is a serious objection to which version of the moral argument?

- A. Kant's postulate of God as guarantor of the proportion between virtue and happiness.
- B. Divine-command versions that make God's will the source and standard of moral goodness.
- C. Nyāya's argument from the composite character of the world.
- D. Anselm's second form of the ontological argument.

✓ Correct answer: B. The dilemma forces the divine-command theorist to choose between arbitrariness and a standard independent of God. Kant is insulated because obligation for him is autonomous; the dilemma is irrelevant to C and D, which are not moral arguments at all.

✓ Subtopic 5 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. Proceeding to Indian natural theology.

Progress: 6 / 8 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: Nyāya–Udayana's Proofs for Īśvara

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

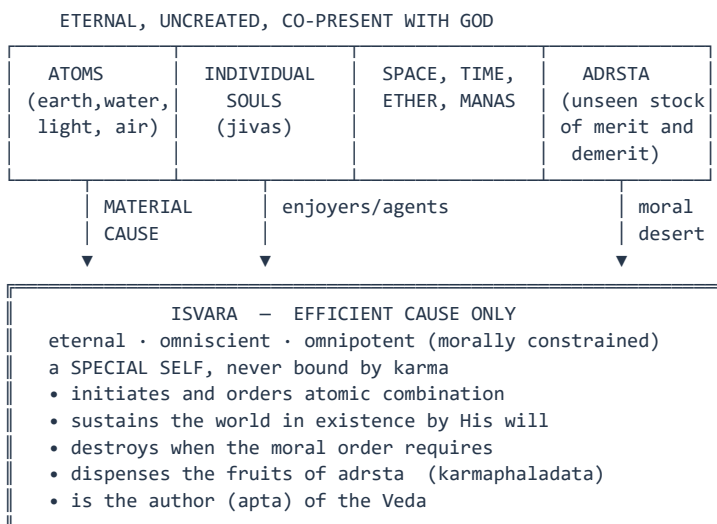
📖 Book context: Proofs-for-God.md §2, §8.4; paper-1/indian/Nyaya-Vaisesika.md; S. C. Chatterjee & D. M. Datta, An Introduction to Indian Philosophy, Chapter V "The Nyāya Theology" — read directly from the local OCR-searchable PDF, covering "The Idea of God", the four proofs set out there (the Causal Argument, the Argument from Adrṣṭa, the Argument from the Authoritativeness of the Scriptures, the Testimony of Śruti) and the section "Anti-theistic Arguments"; also C. D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, for Śaṅkara's critique of the Vaiśeṣika atomistic scheme.

🔍 CA Search: "Nyaya proofs for God, Udayana Nyayakusumanjali, Indian natural theology — recent discussion 2025–2026"

📖 CA Found: No credibly dated Indian-natural-theology news item within the last six months. The subtopic is taught from canonical texts, which is the correct source hierarchy here.



VISUAL — Nyāya's cosmic division of labour



GOD IS NIMITTA-KARANA (efficient cause), NOT UPADANA-KARANA (material cause). Atoms are the material cause.

⚠ Write this distinction in the first two lines of any Nyāya answer. It is the trap the examiner is checking for, and it is the difference between Nyāya and both Advaita and Rāmānuja.

1. The idea of God in Nyāya

✓ God is the creator of the world in the sense of being the first efficient cause of the world and not its material cause — "a sort of demiurgus or a builder of the ordered universe". ✓ He is also the preserver, in so far as the world is kept in existence by the will of God, and the destroyer, who lets loose the forces of destruction when the exigencies of the moral world require it.

✓ God is one, infinite and eternal, since the world of space and time, minds and souls does not limit Him but is related to Him as a body to the self residing in it. ✓ He is omnipotent, although guided in His activities by moral considerations of the merit and demerit of human actions; omniscient, possessing right knowledge of all things and events; and possessed of eternal intelligence as a power of direct and steadfast cognition of all objects.

✓ A precise doctrinal point worth stating: eternal intelligence is only an inseparable attribute of God, not His very essence, as maintained in Advaita Vedānta. ✓ God possesses to the full all the six perfections (ṣaḍ-aiśvarya).

✓ Just as God is the efficient cause of the world, so He is the directive cause of the actions of all living beings. No creature, not even man, is absolutely free; man is relatively free — his actions are done under divine direction and guidance, as a wise and benevolent father directs his son according to his gifts, capacities and previous attainments. ✓ While man is the efficient instrumental cause of his actions, God is their efficient directive cause (prayojaka kartā). God is thus the moral governor of the world, the impartial dispenser of the fruits of our actions (karmaphaladātā), and the supreme arbiter of our joys and sorrows.

△ ✓ Theism, not deism: according to deism, God creates the world at a point of time and then leaves it to itself, having usually no concern with its affairs — like a clock-maker who intervenes only when the clock goes out of order. On the Nyāya theory God maintains a continuous relation with the world, being creator, maintainer and destroyer. This is the essence of theism as distinguished from deism.

2. The proofs — the classical enumeration

✓ Chatterjee and Datta record that "the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣikas have to their credit an array of proofs which include almost all the arguments given in Western philosophy for God's existence. There are as many as ten proofs, of which the more important may be considered here." ? Lists therefore vary across summaries and across editions of Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali (Book V). Use only the arguments the question requires, and say that the list is variously enumerated — that is accuracy, not evasion.

The compact Sanskrit mnemonic set, which the authored knowledge file uses and which UPSC answers should carry:

Term	Literal sense	Argument
✓ Kāryāt	"from the effect"	The composite world is an effect and needs an intelligent maker
✓ Āyojanāt	"from combination/arrangement"	Inert atoms cannot combine purposively by themselves
✓ Dhṛtyādeḥ	"from support/sustenance etc."	The world's being upheld, maintained and destroyed requires governance
✓ Padāt	"from the word"	Linguistic convention and the meaning-relation of words require an authoritative source
✓ Pratyayataḥ / Śruteḥ	"from credibility / from scripture"	The authority of the Veda presupposes a trustworthy omniscient author; and śruti testifies to God
✓ Argument from adṛṣṭa	—	Unconscious merit and demerit require an intelligent dispenser

3. Proof 1 — the causal argument (kāryāt), reconstructed

✓ Premises, in Chatterjee–Datta's own sequence:

1. All composite objects of the world formed by the combination of atoms (mountains, seas, sun, moon, stars, planets) must have a cause, because they are of the nature of EFFECTS – like a pot (ghatavat).
2. That they are effects follows (a) from their being made up of parts (SAVAYAVA), and (b) from their possessing an intermediate magnitude (AVANTARA-MAHATTVA).
3. What is NOT an effect is excluded on the same principle: space, time, ether and self are infinite substances not made of parts; atoms of earth, water, light and air, and manas, are simple, indivisible and infinitesimal.
4. These composite objects are what they are because of the concurrence of a number of MATERIAL causes; but without the guidance of an INTELLIGENT cause (karta) the material causes cannot attain just that order, direction and co-ordination which enables them to produce effects.
5. This intelligent cause must have (i) direct knowledge of the material causes, i.e. the atoms, as means, (ii) a desire to attain some end, and (iii) the power of will to realise the end.
6. He must be OMNISCIENT (sarvajna), since only an omniscient being can have direct knowledge of entities so absolutely simple and infinitely small as atoms.
7. That intelligent cause is God and none but God.

⚠ Notice how much work step 6 does. The move to omniscience is not decorative: it is derived from the requirement of knowing atoms, which are imperceptible to ordinary cognition. This is the step that lifts the argument from "an intelligent artisan" to "an omniscient God", and it is Nyāya's answer to Hume's proportioning objection.

✓ Western parallels, from the same text: the argument resembles the causal argument as explained by Paul Janet (Final Causes), Hermann Lotze (Outlines of a Philosophy of Religion) and James Martineau (A Study of Religion), for whom the world of finite objects requires an intelligent cause giving order and co-ordination to concurrent physical causes.

✓ But the crucial divergence: Western theists generally believe that God is not only the cause of the unity of things but also the creative energy that gives existence to the things of Nature. For the Naiyāyikas, God is only the cause of the order of Nature, and not of the existence of its ultimate constituents.

4. Proof 2 — the argument from adṛṣṭa

✓ The problem: how are we to account for the differences in our lot on earth — some happy, some miserable, some wise, some ignorant? These are events, and every event must have a cause.

✓ Step one: the causes are our own actions in this or some previous life, governed by the moral law of karma, which requires that every individual reap the fruits of its own actions. This follows from extending the law of universal causation to the moral world: just as bodily acts produce bodily changes and mental functions produce mental dispositions, so morally good or bad actions lead to good or bad moral consequences.

✓ Step two — the time-gap problem: how do moral actions produce consequences separated from them by long intervals? "A sinner in the heyday of youth may be a sufferer in the infirmity of old age." Hence good actions produce an efficiency called merit (puṇya) and bad actions a deficiency called demerit (pāpa) in our souls, persisting long after the actions have ceased. This stock of merit and demerit is adṛṣṭa.

✓ Step three — the decisive move: adṛṣṭa is an unintelligent principle which cannot by itself produce just that kind and degree of joy and sorrow which are due to our past actions. It must therefore be guided by an intelligent agent. Individual selves cannot direct it, for they know nothing about their own adṛṣṭa, and it not infrequently defies the control of their will. ∴ The intelligent agent who guides adṛṣṭa through the proper channels is the eternal, omnipotent and omniscient Divine Being, who dispenses all the joys and sorrows of life in strict accordance with it — "as a wise and potent monarch rewards or punishes his subjects according to the merit or guilt attaching to their actions."

✓ Chatterjee and Datta themselves add the Kantian gloss: "Or, as Kant would say, it is God who combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice."

5. Proofs 3 and 4 — the Veda's authority (padāt / āptaprāmāṇya) and śruti's testimony

✓ Proof 3 — from the authoritativeness of the scriptures. The authority (prāmāṇya) of the Vedas has its source in the supreme authority of their author (āptaprāmāṇya). Just as the authoritativeness of medical science, or of any science, derives from the scientists who founded it, so the authoritativeness of the Vedas derives from a person who imparted that character to them. The individual self (jīva) cannot be the author, since the supramundane realities related in the Vedas cannot be objects of an ordinary individual's knowledge. Hence the author must be a supreme person with direct

knowledge of all objects — past, present and future; finite, infinite and infinitesimal; sensible and supersensible. That is, the Vedas are revealed by God.

⚠ Note the neat epistemological analogy embedded here: the Veda may be partially verified in its worldly injunctions (following them produces the desired results), and we accept the whole as authoritative just as we accept a whole science as true when only some parts are verifiable.

✓ Proof 4 — the testimony of śruti. God exists because Vedic scripture bears testimony to His existence — Bṛhadāraṇyaka ("the highest eternal self is the Lord of all, the ruler of all, the protector of all"), Śvetāśvatara ("the one God lies hidden in all, is all-pervading, is the inmost self of all"), Kauṣītaki, and the Bhagavadgītā ("I am the highest end of all, the maintainer of all, the controller of all, the witness of all...").

✓ The circularity objection and Nyāya's reply — a genuinely elegant piece of philosophy that almost no candidate writes. The objection: proof 3 shows God is the author of the Vedas, while proof 4 exhibits the Vedas as the ground of our knowledge of God — a circle. The reply distinguishes the order of existence from the order of knowledge:

ORDER OF EXISTENCE : GOD —creates→ VEDA
ORDER OF KNOWLEDGE : VEDA —leads to→ KNOWLEDGE OF GOD

The Vedas depend on God for their EXISTENCE but not for our KNOWLEDGE of them (they may be learned from a competent teacher);
God depends on the Vedas for our KNOWLEDGE of Him but not for His EXISTENCE.
Reciprocal dependence across two different orders is not a vicious circle.
Circularity arises only within the SAME order or universe of discourse.

⚠ A second classical objection with a dilemma-reply: if God be the creator of the world He must have a body, since without a body no action is possible. The Naiyāyikas reply that the objection is caught between two horns — if God's existence is proved by śruti, arguing against what is already proved is pointless; and if God's existence is not yet granted, the objection presupposes what it disputes.

6. Anti-theistic criticism — including from within the Indian textbook tradition

Critic	Objection	Nyāya reply	Assessment
✓ Cārvāka	God cannot be perceived; the world is made by the automatic combination of the material elements, not by God; inference is unreliable	⚠ Inference is an independent pramāṇa; the Cārvāka's own denial uses inference	⚠ The dispute is really about the scope of pramāṇas
✓ Mīmāṃsā	The Veda is eternal and authorless (apauruṣeya), so no divine author is needed; karma is self-operating	✓ Nyāya: an unconscious principle cannot intelligently allot determinate fruits	? The dispute tracks rival metaphysics of causation and normativity
✓ Buddhism / Jainism	The world runs by karma and conditions without a creator	⚠ Same reply as above, plus the kāryāt premise	⚠ Requires defending the artefact analogy
✓ Śaṅkara (Advaita)	Nyāya's God is a saṁguṇa Īśvara at the empirical level, not the absolute Nirguṇa Brahman; and the atomistic scheme is logically weak	⚠ Nyāya denies that the empirical order is mithyā and defends realist pluralism	⚠ A level-distinction dispute, not a simple refutation
✓ Śaṅkara's atomism dilemma (reported by C. D. Sharma)	Are atoms essentially active, inactive, both or neither? If active, creation is permanent; if inactive, creation is impossible; if both, the conception is self-contradictory; if neither, activity must come from an outside agency — and that agency, seen or unseen, generates further absurdities	⚠ Nyāya locates the initiating impulse in God's will operating through adṛṣṭa	⚠ Sharp, and still discussed

Critic	Objection	Nyāya reply	Assessment
✓ Sharma's own verdict	The Vaiśeṣika God "is not the creator of this universe... He has been reduced to the status of a supervisor," His "hands and feet chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the Adṛṣṭa"; the system "could have easily done away with a God"	△ Nyāya answers that a supervisor who alone can intelligently allot is not dispensable	△ The redundancy objection is the most serious challenge Nyāya theism faces

✓ The textbook's own conclusion, which is examiner-gold when quoted as a critical position: Chatterjee and Datta, invoking Kant and Lotze, argue that none of the so-called proofs can really prove God's existence. To prove anything is to deduce it as a necessary conclusion from given premises; but God, being the ultimate reality, is "the highest of all premises", so there can be no anterior premise from which God is deducible. All the proofs, they say, are vitiated by deducing God's existence from the mere idea of Him: "the idea of the most perfect being may involve the idea of existence, but not actual existence, just as the thought of one hundred rupees in my pocket involves the image or the idea of their existence, but not their real physical existence." Their positive conclusion: God must be known through direct experience, not through reasoning — and they quote Lotze: "all proofs that God exists are pleas put forward in justification of our faith and of the particular way in which we feel that we must apprehend this highest principle."

△ Deploy this as your evaluative paragraph in 2023 Q7(a) and 2025 Q7(b). It lets you criticise Nyāya from within the Indian tradition rather than importing Hume, which is what a first-class script does.

7. Solved PYQ — 2018, Q8(a), 20 marks (the comparison question)

✓ Exact question: "Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyāya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God."

Comparison axis	Aquinas	Nyāya
Epistemic type	✓ A posteriori demonstration (demonstratio quia)	✓ Anumāna requiring vyāpti, modelled on artefacts
Starting facts	Motion, causation, contingency, degrees, purpose	Compositeness, arrangement, maintenance, adṛṣṭa, Vedic authority
Cause of existence	✓ Yes — God creates being itself	✓ No — atoms are eternal, uncreated
Cause of order	Yes	✓ Yes, and only this
Relation to scripture	✓ Proofs are praeambula fidei, from reason alone	✓ Two of the standard proofs are explicitly scriptural
Moral government	Providence	✓ Karmaphaladātā administering adṛṣṭa
Divine attributes reached	Pure act, simplicity, infinity	✓ Omniscience derived from the need to know atoms
Principal internal weakness	Regress-exclusion; the identification with God	Artefact analogy; the redundancy of God given karma
Standard critique	Hume, Kant	Cārvāka, Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā, Advaita

△ The conclusion that earns marks: "Both traditions produce a posteriori natural theology from order to intelligence, and both are attacked on the same two tiers — the strength of the inference and the adequacy of the God reached. They diverge decisively on material causation: Aquinas' God is the source of being, Nyāya's Īśvara only the architect of an eternally given material. The Indian argument is consequently more modest in metaphysical ambition and more exposed to the charge of divine redundancy."

Advanced refinement

△ Udayana's cumulative strategy. Nyāyakusumāñjali does not rest on one inference; it multiplies independent routes — effect, arrangement, sustenance, word-meaning convention, scriptural credibility, moral desert — so that the failure

of any single route does not collapse the case. This is structurally the same move as the modern Western cumulative-case argument, and saying so is a genuinely advanced comparative observation. △ The counter is equally structural: a cumulation of individually weak inferences does not automatically yield a strong one unless the routes are evidentially independent.

UPSC traps

1. △ Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause. Atoms are the eternal material causes.
2. △ Nyāya theism is theism, not deism — God preserves and destroys as well as creates.
3. △ Eternal intelligence is an inseparable attribute of God in Nyāya, not His essence as in Advaita.
4. △ Do not answer "the nature of Nyāya's God" merely by listing Udayana's proofs, or vice versa.
5. △ Adṛṣṭa does not consciously distribute its own fruits — that unconsciousness is the whole premise of the argument.
6. △ Enumerations of the proofs vary; say so and use the ones the question needs.
7. △ The Veda–God circularity is answered by the order-of-existence / order-of-knowledge distinction; do not concede the circle.
8. △ Do not treat Nyāya as "the Indian Aquinas" without flagging the material-causation divergence.

🔗 Mnemonic — "K-A-D-P-Ś + adṛṣṭa": Kāryāt · Āyojanāt · Dhṛtyādeḥ · Padāt · Śruteḥ, plus the argument from adṛṣṭa.

🔗 Second mnemonic — "E-A-K-V": Efficient cause · Atoms · Karma · Veda — the four pillars of Nyāya theology.

Revision notes

- Nyāya's Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient, omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.
- God is the first efficient cause, a builder or demiurgus, not the material cause.
- Atoms, souls, space, time, ether, manas and adṛṣṭa are eternal and co-present with God.
- God is creator, preserver and destroyer — hence theism, not deism.
- God is prayojaka kartā, the efficient directive cause of human action; man is relatively free.
- God is karmaphaladātā, impartial dispenser of the fruits of action.
- Eternal intelligence is an inseparable attribute of God, not His essence.
- Kāryāt: the composite world (sāvayava, avāntara-mahattva) is an effect and needs an intelligent maker.
- Omniscience is inferred because only an omniscient being can directly know atoms.
- Āyojanāt: inert atoms cannot combine purposively without a conscious arranger.
- Dhṛtyādeḥ: the world's support, maintenance and destruction require governance.
- Adṛṣṭa argument: unconscious merit and demerit require an intelligent dispenser.
- Padāt / āptaprāmāṇya: the Veda's authority presupposes an omniscient trustworthy author.
- Śruteḥ: scriptural texts testify to God's existence.
- The circularity charge is met by distinguishing the order of existence from the order of knowledge.
- The bodiless-agent objection is answered by a dilemma.
- Janet, Lotze and Martineau are the Western parallels; but they make God the source of existence, Nyāya only of order.
- Cārvāka, Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Jainism and Advaita each reject the proofs on distinct grounds.
- Śaṅkara's dilemma of active/inactive atoms attacks the whole Vaiśeṣika cosmology.
- Chatterjee–Datta conclude with Kant and Lotze that no proof proves God; direct experience is required.
- Sharma's redundancy objection — Nyāya "could have easily done away with a God" — is the sharpest internal criticism.

MCQ 1

In Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika, God's relation to the world is best described as that of:

- A. The material cause who transforms His own being into atoms and souls.
- B. A non-intervening designer who creates and then withdraws from the world.
- C. Both the material and the efficient cause, as in Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita.
- D. The intelligent efficient cause who orders eternally existing atoms and continues to sustain and destroy the world, while the atoms remain its material cause.

✓ Correct answer: D. A confuses Nyāya with Vedāntic upādāna; B is deism, explicitly rejected because Nyāya's God maintains a continuous relation with the world; C is Rāmānuja's double-causation doctrine, not Nyāya's.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

The Nyāya argument from adṛṣṭa infers God because:

- A. Adṛṣṭa is a conscious moral force that requires a body through which to act.
- B. Adṛṣṭa, being an unintelligent principle, cannot by itself allot precisely the kind and degree of joy and sorrow deserved, and individual selves neither know nor control their own adṛṣṭa.
- C. The Vedas assert that adṛṣṭa is created by God at the beginning of each cycle.
- D. Without God, the law of karma would produce no effects at all.

✓ Correct answer: B. A contradicts the premise that adṛṣṭa is unconscious; C misdescribes adṛṣṭa, which is generated by the soul's own past actions; D overstates — the Nyāya claim is about determinate allocation, not about karma producing no effects whatever.

✓ Subtopic 6 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. Proceeding to the Indian anti-theistic critique.

Progress: 7 / 8 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: Jaina Proofs and the Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka Anti-Creator Critiques

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Proofs-for-God.md §2 critique block; paper-1/indian/Jainism.md (§1.6 nature of jīva, §3.6 kevala-jñāna, §3.7 mokṣa, trap 4), paper-1/indian/Buddhism.md §5 "Buddhist arguments against a creator God", paper-1/indian/Mimamsa.md §9 "Authority of the Veda" and §10.3 apūrva; C. D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, "Ethics and Religion" (Jainism), read from the local PDF — the decisive formula "though Jainism denies God, it does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god"; and Chatterjee & Datta on the Mīmāṃsā rejection of a creator God, including the report of Max Müller's argument that a creator God would be liable to charges of cruelty and partiality.

🔍 CA Search: "Jaina and Buddhist arguments against a creator God, Mimamsa apauruseya — recent scholarly discussion 2025–2026"

📖 CA Found: No credibly dated item within the last six months on the Indian anti-creator arguments specifically. Taught from canonical sources.

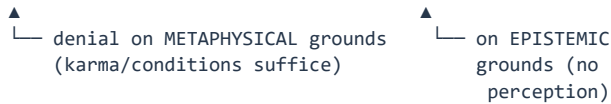


VISUAL — Two completely different senses of "God" in the Indian debate

SENSE 1 : GOD AS WORLD-MAKER (jagat-kartā)

Affirmed by : Nyaya-Vaisesika (efficient cause), theistic Vedanta

DENIED by : JAINA · BAUDDHA · MIMAMSA · SANKHYA · CARVAKA



SENSE 2 : GOD AS PERFECTED BEING (paramatman / siddha / arhat)

AFFIRMED by JAINISM : "Jainism denies God, but does not deny GODHEAD.

EVERY LIBERATED SOUL IS A GOD."

Godhood is ACHIEVED, not eternal · PLURAL, not unique ·
a MODEL, not a maker.

THEREFORE the 2019 question "proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism" is answered in SENSE 2, together with Jainism's refutation of SENSE 1. Answering only "Jainism is atheistic" mis-reads the question.

⚠ This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic. UPSC's 2019 wording presupposes that Jainism has something to prove; the mature answer explains which sense of "God" Jainism proves and which it refutes.

Part I — Jainism

1. What Jainism denies

✓ ⚠ Jainism is "a religion without God" in the sense of a creator. ✓ There is no necessity of bringing in God to explain creation, for the world was never created: production, destruction and permanence characterise all substances; things have creation and dissolution because of their modes (paryāya), while the substances themselves are eternal. The six dravyas — jīva, pudgala, dharma, adharma, ākāśa and kāla — are beginningless.

✓ ⚠ Terminological caution that impresses examiners: nāstika in Indian philosophy standardly means "one who denies the authority of the Veda", not "one who denies the spirit". In that Vedic sense Jainism and Buddhism are nāstika; but they are intensely spiritual and ethical, and denial of God does not amount to atheism in the Western sense — otherwise Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which likewise do not believe in a creator God, could not have been counted orthodox.

2. What Jainism affirms — godhood, and the proofs for it

✓ "Though Jainism denies God, it does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god." ✓ The Tīrthaṅkaras, who were mortal beings like us but obtained liberation through personal effort, are always there to inspire us. We are all potential Jinas, for what man has done man can do. Jainism is a religion of self-help.

⚠ The Jaina "proofs" are therefore proofs of the possibility and actuality of divine perfection in the soul, arranged as follows:

PROOF 1 – FROM THE INTRINSIC NATURE OF THE JIVA (svabhava-siddhi)

1. Every jiva intrinsically possesses infinite knowledge, infinite perception, infinite bliss and infinite power (ananta-catustaya).
2. Empirically these are obscured, not absent, since we observe DEGREES of knowledge, not its total absence.
3. Obscuration is caused by karmic matter (pudgala) adhering to the soul.
4. Remove the obscuring karma completely and the native perfections manifest completely.
5. Godhood is the soul's own nature recovered, not a status conferred from outside. [RECOVERY, not creation]

PROOF 2 – FROM DEGREES OF KNOWLEDGE TO OMNISCIENCE (sarvajna-siddhi)

1. Knowledge occurs in graded kinds: mati, sruta, avadhi, manahparyaya.
2. The gradation maps the progressive removal of karmic obstruction.
3. A graded series of obstruction-removal has a limiting case: COMPLETE removal.
4. At that limit knowledge is total, direct and unobstructed = KEVALA-JNANA.
5. An omniscient being (kevalin) is possible, and the Tirthankaras are its actual instances.

PROOF 3 – FROM THE TESTIMONY OF THE OMNISCIENT (apta / agama)

1. Right faith rests on the teaching of the omniscient Tirthankaras.
2. Their teaching is internally coherent, ascetically verified and transmitted through the Agama.
3. Their attained godhood is credible on the strength of apta-vacana.

△ ✓ Sharma states the epistemic role of Proof 3 exactly: faith is necessary because the deepest truths rest on the word "of the omniscient Tirthankaras"; and right faith, right knowledge and right conduct — the tri-ratna — jointly constitute the path.

✓ The resulting concept of God: plural (infinitely many siddhas), achieved (not eternal in status), non-creative (no cosmic function), non-interventionist (a siddha does not answer prayer or dispense karma), and purely exemplary. △ Sharma notes the historical tension frankly: strictly there is no room for devotion in Jainism, since asceticism must burn all emotion to ashes; yet the ordinary Jaina, under Brahmanical influence, has deified the Tirthankaras, built temples and worshipped their images.

3. Jaina refutation of a creator God

△ The classical Jaina anti-creator arguments (developed in the Digambara tradition and standard in Indian philosophical summaries) run:

#	Argument	Force
1	△ From what did God create? If from pre-existing matter, matter is uncreated and God is not the sole ultimate; if from nothing, anything could be produced anywhere at any time.	Attacks the coherence of creation
2	△ Why did God create? A perfect being has no unfulfilled desire; a motive implies lack.	Attacks divine perfection
3	△ If out of compassion, the world should contain only happiness.	Empirical refutation
4	△ If in sport (līlā), God is childish, and cruel toward the suffering.	Moral refutation
5	△ Who created God? If God is self-existent, the world may equally be self-existent — the theist's own concession destroys the argument.	Regress / parity
6	✓ Karma suffices. The world-order and the distribution of pleasure and pain are explained by each soul's own karmic matter; no external allocator is required.	Explanatory economy

✓ The Jaina positive alternative: the universe is eternal and uncreated; utpāda-vyaya-dhauvya (origination, decay, permanence) is the structure of every substance; change is real without a changer standing outside.

4. Solved PYQ — 2019, Q5(e), 10 marks

✓ Exact question: "State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism."

- 1 min : Disambiguate "God" – Jainism denies jagat-karta but affirms GODHEAD.
 4 min : The three Jaina routes – intrinsic ananta-catustaya of the jiva; the gradation of knowledge culminating in kevala-jnana; the testimony of the omniscient Tirthankaras (apta-vacana).
 2 min : The refutation of a creator – motive, material, compassion, sport, regress, karmic sufficiency.
 2 min : EVALUATE – the proofs succeed in establishing an ideal of attainable perfection, but they are internal to Jaina metaphysics: they presuppose the soul's intrinsic omniscience and material karma. They do NOT prove, and do not attempt to prove, a cosmic God.
 1 min : Verdict – Jaina theology is a soteriological, not a cosmological, theism; "God" names the terminus of the path, not its author.

⚠ Evaluation lines available from within the Indian tradition (use one, not all): Sharma presses the classic realist-pluralist difficulty — if ignorance and karma are inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if they are external to it, bondage is impossible — and holds that the Jainas have no real answer. If the soul is by nature pure consciousness and power, how can it be really tinged with ignorance, passion and karma? This objection strikes at the very premise on which Proof 1 rests.

Part II — Buddhism

5. The Buddhist arguments against a creator God

✓ Four core lines, as recorded in the authored knowledge file:

- ✓ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.
- ✓ If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness.
- ✓ The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
- ✓ Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

⚠ Three further lines that raise a 15-marker to distinction level:

- ⚠ The doctrinal-method argument. Questions about a first beginning belong to the avyākṛta (undeclared) questions; the Buddha's refusal to answer them is not evasion but a judgement that they are soteriologically idle — the parable of the man wounded by an arrow, who dies while demanding to know the archer's caste before allowing the arrow to be drawn.
- ⚠ The moral-agency argument. If God determines all, karma and moral effort are meaningless; if God does not determine all, God is not the sufficient cause and the theistic explanation is redundant.
- ⚠ The Dharmakīrti / Śāntarakṣita line. A permanent, partless, immutable cause cannot produce successive effects, since a cause that is unchanging and fully present must produce its effect all at once and always; therefore an eternal God cannot be the cause of a temporally ordered world.

✓ Philosophical force, stated correctly: the Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus. If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed. It is Ockhamite before Ockham.

⚠ Presupposition to expose: the critique assumes (i) that explanation should proceed through conditional relations rather than through a substratum or an external agent, and (ii) that what matters philosophically is not an absolutely first beginning but the structure by which bondage is maintained here and now.

6. Solved PYQ — 2018, Q8(b), 15 marks

✓ Exact question: "Critically evaluate the Buddhist arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world."

FRAME : Buddhism denies a creator without denying the sacred; the target is jagat-karta, not spiritual ultimacy.

STATE : (a) eternal unchanging cause cannot create; (b) creation from desire implies lack; (c) suffering tells against a benevolent omnipotent creator; (d) pratityasamutpada makes a creator explanatorily redundant; (e) the avyakṛta silence; (f) the freedom/karma dilemma; (g) Dharmakīrti: a permanent cause cannot yield successive effects.

CRITIQUE: – (i) Nyāya replies that unconscious karma cannot intelligently allot determinate fruits, so dependent origination explains sequence but not desert-appropriate ALLOCATION.

– (ii) The change objection assumes a temporal model of divine willing; classical theism replies with an eternal act producing a temporal effect.

– (iii) The desire objection assumes creation must satisfy a lack; theists appeal to gratuitous diffusive goodness.

– (iv) Explanatory economy is a methodological preference, not a disproof.

ASSESS : the arguments are strong AGAINST an anthropomorphic, purposive, benevolent world-maker; weaker against a metaphysically refined classical theism. They shift the burden rather than close the case.

CONCLUDE: Buddhism establishes that a coherent, ethically serious cosmology is possible without a creator – which is a substantial result even if it is not a demonstration of atheism.

Part III — Mīmāṃsā

7. Why Mīmāṃsā needs no God

✓ The Veda is authoritative because it is apauruṣeya — eternal, authorless and self-valid. It is not authored by any human, nor is a divine author needed. ✓ Authorlessness protects it from personal defects: a personal author may deceive, or may lack complete knowledge; if the Veda had an author, its authority would depend on first proving that author's competence and sincerity.

✓ The direct counter to Nyāya's proof 3: Mīmāṃsā objects that the Nyāya route is cumbersome — first prove God exists, then prove God is omniscient, then prove God intends truth, each stage needing independent support. Authorlessness avoids the entire dependence. ✓ Coupled with svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of cognition), this blocks scepticism at the starting point without theological guarantee.

✓ And the direct counter to Nyāya's adṛṣṭa proof: apūrva is the unseen potency produced by correctly performed ritual; it persists after the act and matures into future fruit. This allows Mīmāṃsā to explain ritual efficacy without God as fruit-dispenser. Prābhākara adds niyoga: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one ought to act because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards.

✓ Chatterjee–Datta's report of the wider debate: the Mīmāṃsā rejects the proofs of God's existence, like the Jains, without replacing them by others. They also record Max Müller's contention that if God were supposed to be the creator, He would be liable to the charges of cruelty and partiality; and Müller's further point that rejection of a creator-God is not necessarily rejection of God, since pantheisms such as Advaita and Spinoza's do not accept the reality of creation and yet are not fairly called atheistic. ⚠ Their own verdict is more sceptical: judged by what the Mīmāṃsā itself does and says, the Vedic deities are not treated as objects of worship and are not believed to exist anywhere except in the mantras that describe them — "eternal and self-manifesting concepts", like the immortal characters of classical epics. ⚠ In its anxiety to maintain the supremacy of the Vedas, the Mīmāṃsā "relegates God to an ambiguous position".

8. Cārvāka — and the Nyāya replies to all three

✓ Cārvāka: the existence of God is a myth; God cannot be perceived; the world is made by the automatic combination of the material elements and not by God; no faith should be put in the Vedas. ⚠ Perception alone is a pramāṇa, so inference — on which every theistic proof depends — is unreliable.

Objector	Core claim	⚠ Nyāya's reply	Assessment
Cārvāka	No perception of God; inference invalid	Inference is an independent pramāṇa; the Cārvāka's own general denial itself requires inference	⚠ The dispute is about the scope of pramāṇas, not about God directly

Objector	Core claim	△ Nyāya's reply	Assessment
Buddhism	Conditions suffice; a permanent cause cannot produce successive effects	An unconscious causal nexus explains sequence but not desert-appropriate allocation	? Rival metaphysics; no knock-down
Jainism	Karma is material and self-operating; creation never happened	Material karma still requires an intelligent principle to allot determinate fruits	△ Nyāya's reply presupposes what Jainism denies
Mīmāṃsā	Veda is apauruṣeya; apūrva self-matures	Unconscious apūrva cannot intelligently proportion fruit to desert; authorless language is normatively unexplained	? The deepest and most evenly matched Indian dispute
Advaita	Nyāya's Īśvara is only saguṇa, empirically valid; atomism is incoherent	Realist pluralism denies the mithyā verdict on the empirical order	△ A level-distinction dispute

Advanced refinement

△ The structural symmetry worth naming in a 20-marker. Every Indian anti-creator argument is one of exactly three moves: (i) an economy move — the explanandum is already explained (dependent origination, karma, apūrva); (ii) a coherence move — the divine attributes are internally inconsistent with the act of creating (immutability vs willing, perfection vs motive); or (iii) an epistemic move — the required pramāṇa is unavailable (Cārvāka's restriction to perception; Mīmāṃsā's insistence that the Veda's authority is intrinsic). Classifying the objections this way, rather than listing them by school, is exactly what "critically evaluate" invites — and it lets you show that the Nyāya replies also fall into three matching families.

India–West comparison

Objection type	Indian instance	Western counterpart
Explanatory economy	✓ Pratītyasamutpāda; karma; apūrva	✓ Darwinian natural selection; Hume's Epicurean hypothesis
Coherence of attributes	△ Immutable cause cannot produce successive effects	✓ Omnipotence paradoxes; immutability vs responsiveness
Evil	✓ Suffering vs a benevolent creator; Müller's cruelty/partiality charge	✓ Hume's fifth front; the evidential problem of evil
Epistemic restriction	✓ Cārvāka's perception-only	✓ Logical positivist verificationism
Authority without an author	✓ Mīmāṃsā apauruṣeya	△ No close Western analogue — a genuinely distinctive Indian contribution

UPSC traps

1. △ Jainism denies God but not godhead. Answering the 2019 question with "Jainism is atheistic" misreads it.
2. △ Jaina godhood is plural, achieved and non-creative; a siddha has no cosmic function.
3. △ Jaina karma is material (pudgala); do not equate it with Nyāya's adṛṣṭa or a generic moral force.
4. △ Nāstika means denier of Vedic authority, not denier of spirit.
5. △ Buddhism's critique is a refusal of explanatory surplus, not a proof of atheism.
6. △ The avyākṛta silence is a methodological judgement, not agnostic evasion.
7. △ Mīmāṃsā's Veda is authorless — not God-authored; this is the exact contradictory of Nyāya's third proof.
8. △ Apūrva is Mīmāṃsā's substitute for a fruit-dispensing God; do not call it "karma" loosely.
9. △ Do not say Sāṃkhya "has no view"; classical Sāṃkhya is nirīśvara and also denies a creator.
10. △ Do not present these schools as a single "Indian atheism". Their grounds differ — economy, coherence, epistemic restriction.

 *Mnemonic — "E-C-E": every Indian anti-creator argument is an Economy, Coherence or Epistemic move.*

Revision notes

- Jainism denies a creator God but affirms godhood: every liberated soul is a god.
- The world was never created; substances are eternal and change through modes.
- Utpāda–vyaya–dhrauvya — origination, decay and permanence characterise all substances.
- Jaina proof 1: the jīva's intrinsic ananta-catuṣṭaya is obscured, not absent.
- Jaina proof 2: graded knowledge (matī, śruta, avadhi, maṇaḥparyāya) has a limiting case in kevala-jñāna.
- Jaina proof 3: the testimony of the omniscient Tīrthaṅkaras (āpta-vacana).
- Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who attained liberation by personal effort — "we are all potential Jinas".
- Jaina anti-creator arguments: material of creation, motive, compassion, sport, regress, karmic sufficiency.
- Sharma's internal objection: if karma is inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if external, bondage is.
- Nāstika means denier of Vedic authority; Jainism and Buddhism are nāstika only in that sense.
- Buddhism: an immutable eternal cause cannot create; creation from desire implies lack.
- Buddhism: suffering counts against a benevolent creator; dependent origination makes God redundant.
- The avyākṛta questions and the arrow parable show the critique is soteriological in motive.
- Dharmakīrti-type argument: a permanent cause cannot produce successive effects.
- Mīmāṃsā: the Veda is apauruṣeya, eternal and authorless; no divine author is needed.
- Authorlessness protects the Veda from an author's deceit or ignorance.
- Mīmāṃsā's objection to Nyāya: proving God, then omniscience, then truthfulness, is cumbersome.
- Apūrva explains ritual fruit without a divine dispenser; niyoga grounds obligation in injunction.
- Max Müller: a creator God would face charges of cruelty and partiality.
- Cārvāka: God is unperceived; the world results from the automatic combination of elements.
- All Indian anti-creator arguments reduce to economy, coherence or epistemic-restriction moves.

MCQ 1

The question "State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism" is best answered by explaining that:

- A. Jainism offers a cosmological proof for a creator God who arranges eternal atoms.
- B. Jainism denies a creator God but affirms godhood — every liberated soul is a god — and its "proofs" establish the soul's intrinsic infinite perfections, the limiting case of kevala-jñāna, and the testimony of the omniscient Tīrthaṅkaras.
- C. Jainism accepts the Vedic testimony to God's existence while rejecting inference.
- D. Jainism holds that God is the material cause of the world and that souls are His modes.

✓ Correct answer: B. A describes Nyāya; C contradicts Jainism's rejection of Vedic authority; D describes a Vedāntic position. The examinable insight is the disambiguation between God-as-world-maker and God-as-perfected-being.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

Which pair correctly matches a school with its reason for dispensing with a creator God?

- A. Mīmāṃsā — because the world is a momentary stream of dharmas requiring no substratum.
- B. Buddhism — because the Veda is eternal and authorless, so no divine author is required.
- C. Mīmāṃsā — because the Veda is apauruṣeya and apūrva matures into fruit without a divine dispenser; Buddhism — because dependent origination explains arising through conditions.

D. Cārvāka — because karmic matter obscures the soul's intrinsic omniscience.

✓ Correct answer: C. A and B swap the two schools' characteristic reasons; D attributes a Jaina doctrine to the Cārvāka, who denies both soul and karma.

✓ Subtopic 7 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. Proceeding to the final synthesis.

Progress: 8 / 8 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: Comparative Synthesis and Answer-Writing Architecture

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

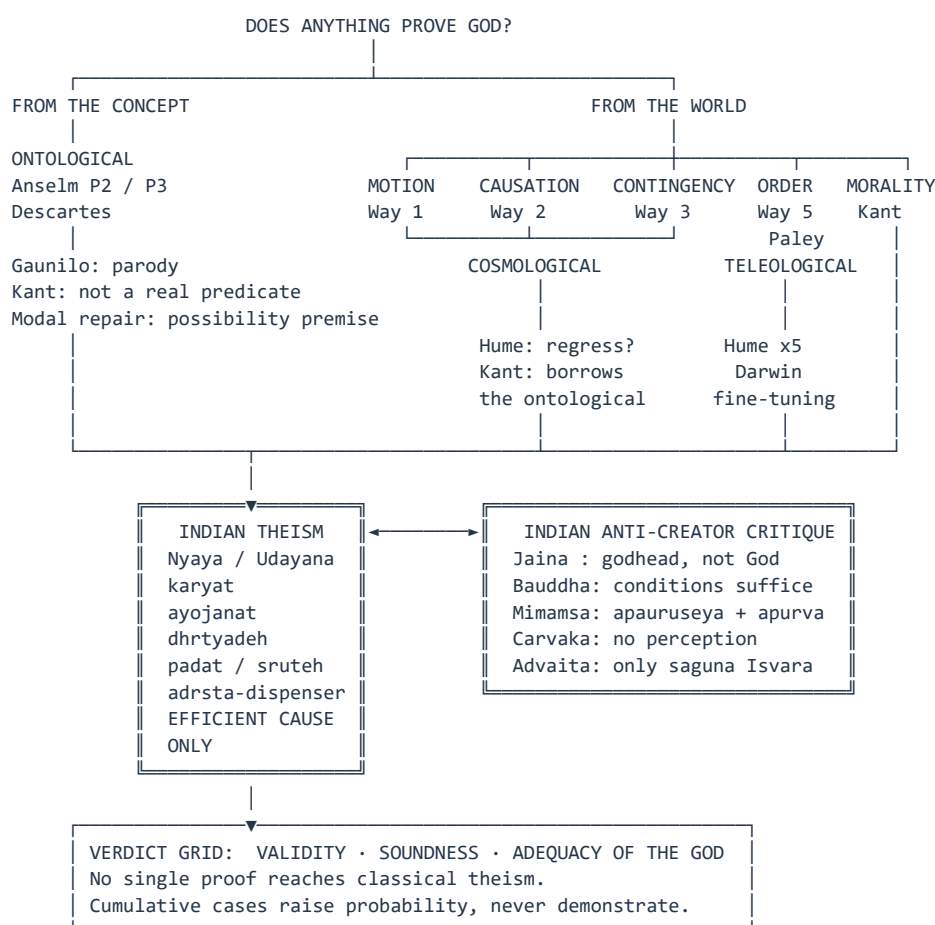
📖 Book context: Proofs-for-God.md §9, §10, §11, §13, §14; _advanced/Philosophy-of-Religion-Dossier.md §2 on modal ontological arguments, the PSR-versus-brute-fact dispute, fine-tuning/Bayesian cumulative cases, and Udayana-style cumulative Nyāya theism; all six preceding subtopics of this session consolidated.

🔍 CA Search: "cumulative case for theism, fine-tuning versus multiverse — 2025–2026 state of debate"

📖 CA Found: 📖 As recorded in Subtopic 1, the 2026 paper and 2025 review both present cumulative cases combining cosmological, teleological, moral and (in the 2026 paper) further arguments, and both engage fine-tuning. This confirms that the cumulative-case strategy is the live contemporary form of the debate. Dated anchor only.



MASTER CONCEPT MAP — the whole syllabus item on one page



1. The master comparison table

Proof	Starting point	Conclusion claimed	Indian parallel	Main critic	What actually survives
Ontological	✓ Concept of maximal being	Necessary existence	⚠ No exact classical analogue	Gaunilo, Kant	⚠ A conditional: if possible, then necessary
Cosmological	✓ Motion, causation, contingency	First / necessary cause	✓ Nyāya kāryāt	Hume, Kant	⚠ An explanatory demand, not a demonstration
Design	✓ Order, adaptation, fine order	Intelligent designer	✓ Nyāya āyojanāt	Hume, Darwin	⚠ Inference to the best explanation, at best
Moral	✓ Moral law and the highest good	Practical postulate	✓ Nyāya karmaphaladātā	Naturalist axiology, Euthyphro	⚠ A rational hope internal to moral seriousness
Nyāya inference	✓ World as composite kārya	Omniscient efficient cause	—	Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Jainism, Cārvāka	⚠ A cumulative theism vulnerable to the redundancy charge
Mīmāṃsā counter	✓ Eternal Veda; self-operating apūrva	No creator required	—	Nyāya	✓ A coherent non-theistic account of normativity
Jaina counter	✓ Uncreated world; material karma	Godhood without God	—	Nyāya	✓ A soteriological theism without cosmology

2. Criticisms and replies — the consolidated grid

Objection	Proof affected	Reply	Assessment
✓ "Existence is not a predicate"	Ontological	⚠ Modal versions use necessary existence	⚠ The possibility premise now bears the burden
✓ Fallacy of composition	Cosmological	⚠ The argument concerns dependence, not property-transfer	⚠ Must be framed as an essentially ordered series
✓ Infinite regress may be acceptable	Cosmological	⚠ An infinite series of derivative causes supplies no actualising power	⚠ Requires proving the series is per se
✓ Cosmological borrows the ontological	Cosmological	⚠ Thomists identify the necessary being with God by further argument	⚠ That further argument is disputable
✓ Weak world–artefact analogy	Design, Nyāya	⚠ Treat as probabilistic rather than deductive	⚠ The conclusion becomes modest
✓ Natural selection explains adaptation	Paley	⚠ Relocate to law-governedness and fine-tuning	⚠ Rivals (multiverse) remain available
✓ Cause need not be one, personal or perfect	Cosmological, design	⚠ Cumulative arguments add attributes	✓ No single proof reaches classical theism
✓ Karma can operate without God	Nyāya	⚠ Intelligent allocation explains determinate desert	? Tracks rival metaphysics
✓ The Veda needs no author	Nyāya padāt/śruteḥ	⚠ Authorless normativity is itself unexplained	? The most evenly matched Indian dispute

Objection	Proof affected	Reply	Assessment
✓ Moral values may be naturalistically explained	Moral	⚠ Kant postulates rather than infers	⚠ The postulate can still be declined
⚠ Divine redundancy (Sharma)	Nyāya	⚠ A supervisor who alone allots is not dispensable	⚠ Nyāya's hardest challenge

3. Four verdicts you may safely defend

⚠ Choose one as the thesis of any answer, and defend it; do not hedge across all four.

- V1 MINIMAL : No proof is demonstrative; each fails on validity, soundness or adequacy. (Chatterjee-Datta, following Kant and Lotze.)
- V2 CUMULATIVE: Individually weak, jointly they raise the probability of theism. (Udayana; Swinburne; the 2025-26 literature.)
- V3 DIVERGENT : Different proofs establish different things – necessity, agency, intelligence, moral government – and no single one was ever meant to deliver the whole God of religion.
- V4 EXPERIENTIAL: Proofs are "pleas put forward in justification of our faith" (Lotze); God must be known through direct experience, not through reasoning. (Chatterjee-Datta's own conclusion.)

4. India and the West — convergence and divergence

Axis	✓ Convergence	✓ Divergence
Method	Both build a posteriori inferences from order to intelligence	⚠ India has no a priori ontological route; Nyāya requires vyāpti
Object established	Both reach an intelligent cause	✓ Aquinas' God causes being; Nyāya's Īśvara causes only order
Material cause	—	✓ Creation ex nihilo vs eternal atoms
Moral government	✓ Providence ≈ karmaphaladātā	⚠ Kant postulates it; Nyāya infers it
Scriptural authority	Both invoke revelation somewhere	✓ Nyāya makes God the Veda's author; Mīmāṃsā makes the Veda authorless — no Western analogue
Anti-theistic critique	✓ Both traditions field economy, coherence and evil-based objections	⚠ India's critiques come from within orthodoxy (Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya), not only from sceptics

⚠ The best single comparative sentence in the topic: "Nyāya and Western natural theology converge in inferring from order to intelligence, but diverge over material causation and karma — and where the West's sharpest critics stood outside religion, India's stood inside it."

5. Answer architecture

10 marks (≈150 words, 7–8 minutes)

Name and classify the proof → state its premises in sequence → identify ONE presupposition → give the canonical objection → one-sentence verdict on what the proof actually establishes.

15 marks (≈220–260 words, 12–13 minutes)

Frame the explanatory question the proof answers → reconstruct the argument as numbered steps → give the canonical example (watch, pot, stick-stone) → the critic's strongest objection → the proponent's best reply → assess VALIDITY and the ADEQUACY OF THE CONCLUSION SEPARATELY.

20 marks (≈320–360 words, 17–18 minutes)

Classify the family of proofs → full internal steps → contrast the Indian/Western analogue → TWO objections with replies → the underdetermination of divine attributes → a graded, criterion-named conclusion.

6. PYQ routing — the complete 2018–2025 map

Year	Q	Marks	Demand	Session route
2018	Q6(c)	15	Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? (ontological)	Subtopic 2 §8
2018	Q8(a)	20	Compare Aquinas' five ways with Nyāya's arguments	Subtopics 3 + 6
2018	Q8(b)	15	Critically evaluate the Buddhistic arguments against a creator God	Subtopic 7 Part II
2019	Q5(e)	10	State and evaluate the Jaina proofs	Subtopic 7 Part I
2020	Q6(a)	20	Is Anselm's ontological proof logical?	Subtopic 2
2021	Q7(b)	15	Critical account of the moral argument	Subtopic 5
2022	Q6(a)	20	Critical exposition of the Five Ways; which is most interesting?	Subtopics 3 + 4
2022	Q8(a)	20	A priori vs a posteriori; which is preferable?	Subtopic 1 §2
2023	Q7(a)	20	Critically examine Nyāya's arguments	Subtopic 6
2024	Q7(c)	15 (10+5)	Exposition of the ontological proof with criticism	Subtopic 2
2025	Q6(a)	20	Design argument with Hume's criticism	Subtopic 4
2025	Q7(b)	15	What proofs do Nyāya philosophers offer?	Subtopic 6

7. "Which Way is philosophically most interesting?" — handling the 2022 evaluative demand

⚠ The question invites a defended personal judgement. The two strongest defensible answers:

Choice	Why defensible	What you must then show
⚠ Way 3 (contingency)	It alone asks the deepest question — why is there anything at all rather than nothing? — and connects to the live PSR/brute-fact debate	That you can state the quantifier-shift objection and the ab alio / a se distinction
⚠ Way 5 (purposiveness)	It generates the richest downstream tradition — Paley, Hume, Darwin, fine-tuning — and is the one still being fought over	That you can separate Aquinas' regularity premise from Paley's analogy

⚠ What loses marks: choosing Way 2 and describing it as "the first cause who started the universe", which is not Aquinas' argument at all.

8. Original practice — Mains questions for this session

⚠ Attempt these under time before consulting the workbook.

1. (10) Distinguish an essentially ordered from an accidentally ordered causal series, and explain why the distinction is indispensable to Aquinas' Second Way.
2. (10) "Jainism denies God but not godhead." Examine.
3. (15) Does the modal version of the ontological argument escape Kant's objection? Discuss.
4. (15) Examine the Mīmāṃsā case that the authority of the Veda and the operation of karma together render a creator God redundant.
5. (20) "Hume did not disprove design; he dismantled the inference." Critically examine with reference to the Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion.
6. (20) Compare Kant's postulation of God from the highest good with the Nyāya inference of God as karmaphaladātā.

9. Model philosophical conclusion

△ "The proofs for God's existence fail as demonstrations but succeed as diagnostics. The ontological argument shows that God, if real, cannot be a contingent item in the world; the cosmological arguments show that contingent reality does not explain itself; the design argument shows that order invites, without compelling, an intentional explanation; the moral argument shows what a serious moral agent must hope; and Nyāya shows that the same inferential path was walked in India, and met the same objections from Mīmāṃsā and Buddhism that Hume and Kant later pressed in Europe. What no proof delivers is the passage from the being it establishes to the God actually worshipped — which is why every tradition, Indian and Western alike, eventually supplements proof with experience, testimony or faith."

Final MCQ 1

Which of the following statements about the relation between the Western and Indian proofs is philosophically accurate?

- A. Nyāya's kāryāt argument and Aquinas' Second Way are identical, since both conclude to a first cause of the world's existence.
- B. The Mīmāṃsā doctrine of apauruṣeya is the Indian equivalent of Kant's claim that existence is not a real predicate.
- C. Nyāya and Aquinas converge in inferring an intelligent cause from order, but diverge decisively on material causation: Aquinas' God confers existence, whereas Nyāya's Īśvara only orders eternally existing atoms.
- D. Hume's critique of design has no application to Nyāya, because Nyāya's inference is not analogical.

✓ Correct answer: C. A ignores the material-causation divergence; B pairs two entirely unrelated doctrines; D is false, since Nyāya's inference is explicitly modelled on the pot and potter and is therefore squarely exposed to Hume's analogy objection.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

Final MCQ 2

Which is the strongest and most defensible concluding verdict on the theistic proofs for a Philosophy Optional answer?

- A. All the proofs succeed, and together they demonstrate the God of classical theism.
- B. All the proofs are worthless, and their failure establishes atheism.
- C. The proofs are valid but their premises are all empirically false.
- D. No single proof is demonstrative; each establishes at most something less than the God of developed religion, so the arguments function as cumulative and diagnostic rather than probative.

✓ Correct answer: D. A overstates; B commits the fallacy of inferring atheism from failed theistic arguments; C misdescribes the situation, since several proofs are contested precisely on validity. D matches the graded, criterion-named verdict UPSC rewards.

✓ Learning session complete: 8/8 subtopics. Final assessment passed with 2 consecutive correct answers.

You now have full coverage of the taxonomy of proofs, the ontological argument and its critics, the cosmological family, design and its modern successors, the moral argument, Nyāya–Udayana theism, and the Jaina, Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka critiques, together with the comparative synthesis and answer architecture.

Commands: [Revise](#) · [PYQ](#) · [Notes](#) · [Export](#) [PDF](#)

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES — Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique

Placement note: These register notes come after all teaching and practice, and cover every one of the eight subtopics taught in this session. They are the last-mile revision layer, not a substitute for the session above.

Register 1 — The architecture of theistic proof

Item	Register entry
Syllabus wording	✓ "Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique (Indian and Western)"
Three senses of "proof"	✓ Demonstration · probable/explanatory inference · practical postulate
The assessment grid	⚠ Validity (does it follow?) → Soundness (are the premises true?) → Adequacy (is the being reached God?)
A priori route	✓ Ontological only (Anselm, Descartes)
A posteriori routes	✓ Cosmological, teleological, moral, Nyāya Īśvara-anumāna
A priori strength / weakness	✓ Yields necessity / ⚠ commits the existence-predicate fallacy
A posteriori strength / weakness	✓ Begins from conceded facts / ⚠ reaches only a probable, finite cause
2022 verdict formula	⚠ Preference depends on the criterion: evidential contact → a posteriori; modal strength → a priori; religious adequacy → neither alone
Mnemonic	🔗 O-C-T-M + N, critiqued by J-B-M

Register 2 — Ontological argument

- ✓ Anselm's definition: "that than which nothing greater can be conceived"; "greater" = more perfect. Not "the most perfect being that there is".
- ✓ First form (Proslogion 2): existing in reality is greater than existing in the mind alone; hence God exists in reality. Addressed to the Psalmist's "fool".
- ✓ Second form (Proslogion 3): a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater; hence God exists necessarily. Core notion = aseity / self-existence.
- ✓ Descartes (Meditations V): existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as three angles to a triangle, or a valley to a mountain.
- ⚠ Descartes' Meditations III causal proof is a different argument — do not merge.
- ✓ Gaunilo, In Behalf of the Fool: the perfect-island parody. ⚠ He should have said "most perfect conceivable island".
- ✓ Anselm's reply: only God is defined with necessary existence; an island is by definition a contingent piece of land surrounded by water.
- ✓ Kant: "existence is not a real predicate"; a hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones.

- ✓ Chatterjee–Datta's Indian idiom: the thought of a hundred rupees in my pocket involves the idea of their existence, not their real physical existence.
- ⚠ Post-Fregean objection: existence is second-order (instantiation of a concept), so it cannot appear among perfections.
- ⚠ Modal repair (Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga): if a maximally great being is possible, it exists necessarily — but the possibility premise bears the whole burden, and a parallel "possibly no such being" reverses the result.
- ⚠ 2018 verdict: the concept entails existence conditionally; it does not entail instantiation.
- ⚠ India: no classical analogue; Indian epistemology grounds existence-claims in world-involving pramāṇas.
- 🔗 A-D-G-K-M: Anselm defines · Descartes essentialises · Gaunilo parodies · Kant diagnoses · Modal logic repairs.

Register 3 — Cosmological arguments

- ✓ Five Ways (ST I q.2 a.3): motion → prime mover; causation → first cause; contingency → necessary being; degrees → maximum; purposiveness → designer. Each ends "and this everyone understands to be God".
- ✓ Ways 1–3 are cosmological; Way 4 is henological; Way 5 is teleological.
- ⚠ Essentially ordered (per se) series: hand → stick → stone; derivative power throughout; removal stops the series now. This is what Aquinas terminates.
- ⚠ Accidentally ordered (per accidens) series: grandfather → father → son; Aquinas need not stop it.
- ✓ "First" = explanatory priority, not the earliest event in time.
- ✓ Aquinas concedes the difficulty of excluding an endless regress of events; he holds the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration.
- ✓ Neo-Thomist reformulation: the excluded series is simultaneous dependence, not backward time.
- ⚠ Way 3's weak steps: possible quantifier shift at "at some time nothing would have existed"; and the necessary ab alio / necessary a se distinction at the end.
- ⚠ Way 4: degrees imply a maximum — defensible only through the metaphysics of participation.
- ⚠ Kalām: whatever begins to exist has a cause; the universe began; ∴ it has a cause. Argues for a temporal beginning — Aquinas does not.
- ⚠ Leibniz/PSR: why is there something rather than nothing? Every fact needs a sufficient reason; a contingent totality is not self-explanatory.
- ✓ Hume: why not an infinite series? explaining each part may explain the whole; the cause need not be one, personal, infinite or good.
- ✓ Kant: the passage from "a necessary being" to "the ens realissimum" is the ontological argument in disguise — an adequacy-tier objection.
- ⚠ Composition charge is met by framing dependence rather than property-transfer.
- 🔗 M-C-C-D-P: Motion, Causation, Contingency, Degrees, Purpose.

Register 4 — Teleological argument

- ✓ Three distinct teleologies: Aquinas' Way 5 (regular directedness of non-cognitive nature; archer and arrow) · Paley's analogy from artefact to organism · modern fine-tuning (probabilistic, pre-biological).
- ✓ The design argument runs from Plato's Timaeus through Aquinas to Paley's Natural Theology (1802).
- ✓ Paley's watch on the heath: wheels, cogs, axles, springs and balances working together for regular timekeeping oblige us to postulate an intelligent maker; a stone does not.
- ✓ Paley's three riders: the inference survives (i) never having seen a watch made, (ii) imperfect working, (iii) parts whose function we cannot discover.
- ✓ Paley's evidence is cumulative: the eye as a self-adjusting optical instrument, the bird's wing, the fish's fin, planetary rotation, the seasons.
- ✓ Hume's Dialogues (1779) precede Paley (1802); Paley took no apparent account of them.

- ✓ Hume front 1: any persisting universe must exhibit adaptation — there could not be birds with wings unable to live in air. Epicurean hypothesis: finite particles in random motion pass through every combination in unlimited time; one is a stable order.
- ✓ Hume front 2: the universe is as like a vegetable or a crustacean as a machine; only strong analogy with a known artefact licenses the inference.
- ✓ Hume front 3: proportion cause to effect — from a finite world one can never infer an infinite creator (the scales illustration).
- ✓ Hume front 4: many designers, an inferior deity, an infant or senile one, or an abandoned first attempt fit the evidence equally.
- ✓ Hume front 5: evil and disorder count against a good and powerful designer.
- ✓ Hume does not disprove a designer; he attacks inference-strength and divine attributes.
- ✓ Darwin: random variation plus differential survival explains adaptation. Ozone illustration: life fitted itself to the filter, not the filter to life.
- ⚠ Darwin's exact scope: defeats Paley's biological premise; does not touch law-governedness or the fine-tuning of constants.
- ⚠ Fine-tuning: Bayesian/explanatory, not analogical; rivals are multiverse plus observation-selection, and brute necessity.
- ✓ Indian analogue: āyōjanāt, pot and potter; Chatterjee–Datta note the parallels in Janet, Lotze and Martineau, but stress that Western theists make God the source of existence while Nyāya makes God only the cause of order.
- 🔗 Hume's five fronts, A-A-P-P-E: Any universe looks adapted · Analogy weak · Proportion cause to effect · Plurality/imperfection of designers · Evil.

Register 5 — Moral argument

- ✓ Kant's two storeys: Critique of Pure Reason destroys the ontological, cosmological and physico-theological proofs; Critique of Practical Reason reinstates God as a postulate.
- ✓ First form (Newman, Grammar of Assent): conscience implies One before whom we are ashamed and responsible.
 - ✓ Hick's objection: it assumes moral values resist naturalistic explanation — which begs the question.
- ✓ Kant's structure: moral law obligates → its complete object is the highest good (virtue + proportionate happiness) → ought implies can → holiness unattainable in finite time (immortality) and nature does not proportion happiness to virtue (God) → plus freedom, presupposed by obligation.
- ✓ Three postulates: freedom, immortality, God.
- ⚠ A postulate is practically necessary, theoretically undemonstrable — Vernunftglaube, rational faith; subjectively sufficient, objectively insufficient assent.
- ✓ Hick's verdict: moral seriousness is "at least a move in the direction of belief in God", but moral values cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, omnipotent, self-existent personal creator.
- ⚠ Objections: projection/wish-fulfilment; autonomy tension; adequacy. Euthyphro strikes divine-command theories, not Kant — for Kant the moral law is autonomous and God guarantees proportion, not obligation.
- ✓ Indian counterpart: Nyāya's karmaphaladātā. Chatterjee–Datta write: "Or, as Kant would say, it is God who combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice."
- ⚠ Key contrast: Kant postulates a God who could proportion; Nyāya infers a God who does — epistemically bolder, correspondingly more exposed.
- 🔗 F-I-G: Freedom · Immortality · God.

Register 6 — Nyāya–Udayana theism

- ✓ Nature of Īśvara: first efficient cause, a demiurgus or builder — not the material cause; also preserver (the world is kept in existence by God's will) and destroyer (when the moral order requires).
- ✓ One, infinite, eternal; the world is related to God as a body to the self residing in it; omnipotent yet guided by the merit and demerit of human actions; omniscient.

- ✓ Eternal intelligence is an inseparable attribute of God, not His essence — the explicit contrast with Advaita.
- ✓ Possesses the six perfections (ṣaḍ-aiśvarya).
- ✓ God is prayojaka kartā — efficient directive cause of human action; man is the efficient instrumental cause and is only relatively free, directed as a wise father directs a son.
- ✓ God is karmaphaladātā — impartial dispenser of the fruits of action, moral governor, supreme arbiter of joys and sorrows.
- ✓ Theism, not deism: the deist's God withdraws like a clock-maker; Nyāya's God maintains a continuous relation as creator, maintainer and destroyer.
- ✓ Ten proofs are claimed; the more important are usually four or five. ? Enumerations vary — say so.
- ✓ Kāryāt: composite objects are effects because they are made of parts (sāvayava) and possess intermediate magnitude (avāntara-mahattva); space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities, and atoms and manas as simple infinitesimals; material causes alone cannot achieve the required order, direction and co-ordination; the intelligent cause must know the atoms, desire an end and will its realisation; and must be omniscient, since only an omniscient being can directly know atoms.
- ✓ Āyojanāt: inert atoms require purposive combination.
- ✓ Dhṛtyādeḥ: support, maintenance and destruction require governance.
- ✓ Padāt / āptaprāmānya: the Veda's authority derives from an omniscient author, as a science's authority derives from its founder; the jīva cannot be that author because supramundane realities exceed ordinary knowledge.
- ✓ Śruteḥ: Bṛhadāraṇyaka, Śvetāśvatara, Kauṣītaki and the Bhagavadgītā testify to God.
- ✓ Argument from adrṣṭa: differences of lot require a cause → karma → the time-gap requires a persisting stock of puṇya and pāpa = adrṣṭa → adrṣṭa is unintelligent and cannot allot the right kind and degree of joy and sorrow; individual selves neither know nor control it → ∴ an eternal, omnipotent, omniscient dispenser.
- ✓ Circularity objection answered: in the order of existence God creates the Veda; in the order of knowledge the Veda leads to God. Reciprocal dependence across different orders is not a vicious circle.
- ✓ Bodiless-agent objection answered by a dilemma: if God's existence is already proved by śruti the objection is idle; if not, it presupposes what it disputes.
- ✓ Western parallels: Janet, Lotze, Martineau; ✓ decisive divergence — they make God the creative energy giving existence to things, Nyāya makes God the cause of order only.
- ⚠ Śaṅkara's atomism dilemma: atoms active → permanent creation; inactive → no creation; both → contradiction; neither → an outside agency, itself problematic.
- ⚠ Sharma's redundancy objection: Nyāya's God is "reduced to the status of a supervisor" with "hands and feet chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the Adrṣṭa"; the system "could have easily done away with a God".
- ✓ Chatterjee–Datta's own conclusion: none of the proofs can prove God, because God, as ultimate reality, is the highest of all premises and cannot be deduced from an anterior one; God must be known through direct experience. Lotze: "all proofs that God exists are pleas put forward in justification of our faith."
- 🔗 K-A-D-P-Ś + adrṣṭa · 🔗 E-A-K-V: Efficient cause · Atoms · Karma · Veda.

Register 7 — Jaina, Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka critiques

Jainism

- ✓ Denies God as creator; the world was never created; substances are eternal and change through modes; utpāda–vyaya–dhrauvya.
- ✓ "Jainism denies God, but does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god." Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who won liberation by personal effort — "we are all potential Jinas". A religion of self-help.
- ⚠ Proof 1 (svabhāva): the jīva intrinsically possesses ananta-catuṣṭaya — infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power — obscured, not absent.
- ⚠ Proof 2 (sarvajña-siddhi): mati, śruta, avadhi and manaḥparyāya map degrees of karmic obstruction; complete removal is the limiting case = kevala-jñāna.

- ⚠ Proof 3 (āpta-vacana): the testimony of the omniscient Tīrthaṅkaras, one leg of the tri-ratna.
- ✓ Jaina God: plural, achieved, non-creative, non-interventionist, exemplary.
- ⚠ Anti-creator arguments: from what material? why create at all (a perfect being lacks nothing)? if from compassion, why suffering? if in sport, God is childish and cruel; who made God — and if God is self-existent, so may the world be; karma suffices.
- ⚠ Sharma's internal objection: if ignorance and karma are inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if external, bondage is impossible.
- ⚠ Nāstika means denier of Vedic authority, not denier of spirit.

Buddhism

- ✓ An eternal unchanging God cannot create, since willing or producing involves change.
- ✓ Creation from desire or purpose implies lack or incompleteness.
- ✓ Suffering and evil sit uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
- ✓ Dependent origination already explains arising through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.
- ⚠ The avyākṛta questions and the arrow parable: first-beginning questions are soteriologically idle.
- ⚠ Freedom/karma dilemma: if God determines all, moral effort is empty; if not, God is not the sufficient cause.
- ⚠ Dharmakīrti-type argument: a permanent, immutable cause cannot produce successive effects.
- ✓ The critique is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus, not bare atheism.
- ⚠ Replies to note: Nyāya on determinate allocation; the eternal-act/temporal-effect answer to the change objection; diffusive goodness against the desire objection; economy is a methodological preference, not a disproof.

Mīmāṃsā

- ✓ The Veda is apauruṣeya — eternal, authorless, self-valid; no human and no divine author is needed.
- ✓ Authorlessness protects it from an author's deceit or ignorance.
- ✓ Against Nyāya: proving God, then His omniscience, then His truthfulness, is a cumbersome three-stage dependence that authorlessness avoids.
- ✓ Apūrva — the unseen potency of correctly performed ritual — matures into future fruit without a divine dispenser; Prābhākara's niyoga grounds obligation in the injunction itself.
- ✓ Chatterjee–Datta record Max Müller's point that a creator God would face charges of cruelty and partiality, and his further point that denying a creator is not denying God.
- ⚠ Their own criticism: Mīmāṃsā deities are not objects of worship and exist only in the mantras describing them — "eternal and self-manifesting concepts"; God is relegated to an ambiguous position.

Cārvāka

- ✓ God cannot be perceived; the world is made by the automatic combination of the material elements; the Vedas and priests are rejected.
- ⚠ Perception alone is a pramāṇa, so every inferential proof is undercut at the outset.

Classification key

- 🔗 E-C-E: every Indian anti-creator argument is an Economy move, a Coherence move, or an Epistemic-restriction move.

Register 8 — Comparative synthesis and answer architecture

Item	Register entry
Convergence	✓ India and the West both build a posteriori inferences from order to intelligence
Divergence 1	✓ Aquinas' God causes being; Nyāya's Īśvara causes only order
Divergence 2	✓ Creation ex nihilo vs eternal atoms as material cause

Item	Register entry
Divergence 3	✓ Nyāya makes God the Veda's author; Mīmāṃsā makes the Veda authorless — no Western analogue
Divergence 4	⚠ India's sharpest anti-theistic critiques come from within orthodoxy (Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya)
Four defensible verdicts	⚠ V1 minimal (no proof is demonstrative) · V2 cumulative · V3 divergent (different proofs establish different things) · V4 experiential (Lotze/Chatterjee–Datta)
10-mark spine	Classify → premises → one presupposition → canonical objection → one-line verdict (≈150 words)
15-mark spine	Frame → reconstruct → canonical example → strongest objection → best reply → assess validity and adequacy separately (≈220–260 words)
20-mark spine	Classify family → full steps → Indian/Western contrast → two objections with replies → underdetermination of attributes → criterion-named graded conclusion (≈320–360 words)
2022 "most interesting Way"	⚠ Defend Way 3 (why anything at all; PSR debate) or Way 5 (richest downstream tradition); never describe Way 2 as "who started the universe"

Register 9 — The eleven master traps

1. ⚠ Do not merge Aquinas' five Ways into one temporal "first cause" argument.
2. ⚠ Do not attribute the watch analogy to Aquinas; it belongs to Paley.
3. ⚠ Do not say Kant proves God through morality; he postulates God for practical reason.
4. ⚠ Do not call Nyāya's God the material cause; atoms are the eternal material causes.
5. ⚠ Do not present Hume as proving that no designer exists; his target is the inference's strength and its conclusion's attributes.
6. ⚠ Distinguish a proof's validity from the adequacy of the God it establishes.
7. ⚠ Do not omit Anselm's second form; the reply to Gaunilo depends on it.
8. ⚠ Modal ontological versions carry a possibility-premise burden; they do not defeat Kant cleanly.
9. ⚠ Mīmāṃsā's Veda is apauruṣeya and karma can be self-operating — the exact contradictory of Nyāya's third and adṛṣṭa proofs.
10. ⚠ "Jainism is atheistic" misreads the 2019 question: Jainism denies God, not godhead.
11. ⚠ Do not conflate the Kalām (temporal beginning) with Aquinas' Ways (explanatory priority).

Register 10 — Keyword and statement bank

Keywords: ✓ a priori · a posteriori · ontological · necessary existence · aseity · real predicate · reductio · maximal greatness · possibility premise · cosmological · essentially ordered series (per se) · accidentally ordered series (per accidens) · contingency · principle of sufficient reason · Kalām · teleological · analogy · means–end adjustment · Epicurean hypothesis · natural selection · fine-tuning · multiverse · summum bonum · practical postulate · Vernunftglaube · autonomy · Euthyphro · kāryāt · āyojanāt · dhṛtyādeḥ · padāt · śruteḥ · sāvayava · avāntara-mahattva · nimitta-kāraṇa vs upādāna-kāraṇa · adṛṣṭa · puṇya / pāpa · karmaphaladātā · prayojaka kartā · ṣaḍ-aiśvarya · ananta-catuṣṭaya · kevala-jñāna · siddha · tri-ratna · utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya · pratītyasamutpāda · avyākṛta · apauruṣeya · svataḥ-prāmāṇya · apūrva · niyoga · āpta-prāmāṇya.

Safe formulations:

- ⚠ "Most proofs underdetermine the rich God of religion."
- ⚠ "Nyāya and Western natural theology converge in inference from order, but diverge over material causation and karma."

- ⚠ "Hume did not disprove design; he dismantled the strength of the inference and the identity of the designer."
- ⚠ "Kant does not prove God; he shows what a serious moral agent must rationally hope."
- ⚠ "Jainism denies God but not godhead: godhood is achieved, plural and non-creative."
- ⚠ "Where the West's sharpest critics of theism stood outside religion, India's stood inside it."

Register 11 — Last-minute memory spine

TAXONOMY : a priori (ontological) | a posteriori (cosmo, teleo, moral, Nyaya)
GRID : validity → soundness → adequacy of the God established
ANSELM : P2 existence · P3 NECESSARY existence · Gaunilo · Kant · modal burden
AQUINAS : motion · causation · contingency · degrees · purpose
 per se series (hand-stick-stone) · "first" = explanatory
DESIGN : Way 5 (archer) ≠ Paley (watch) ≠ fine-tuning (constants)
HUME : A-A-P-P-E (adapted · analogy · proportion · plurality · evil)
KANT : CPR destroys · CPR postulates · F-I-G · summum bonum
NYAYA : K-A-D-P-S + adrsta · EFFICIENT cause only · karmaphaladata
CRITICS : Jaina (godhead, not God) · Bauddha (conditions suffice) ·
 Mimamsa (apauruseya + apurva) · Carvaka (no perception) ·
 Advaita (only saguna) · Sharma (redundancy)
VERDICT : classify → reconstruct → presuppose → object → reply → GRADE

End of the complete learning session and consolidated register notes.